

Open Card Game Rules Reference

Original write-ups of traditional and popular card games

30 games for 1 to 8 players, playable with the decks you already own.

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Contents

SOLITAIRE (1 PLAYER)	4
FreeCell	4
Golf	7
Klondike	9
Pyramid	12
Spider	14
TRICK-TAKING	17
Euchre	17
Hearts	20
Oh Hell	23
Pinochle	26
Spades	29
Whist	32
RUMMY FAMILY	35
500 Rummy	35
Canasta	38
Gin Rummy	41
Rummy	44
SHEDDING	47
Crazy Eights	47
Egyptian Ratscrew	50
Kings in the Corner	53
Palace	56
President	59
Slapjack	62
Speed	65
Spit	68
MATCHING & COLLECTING	71
Casino	71
Cribbage	74
Go Fish	77
Old Maid	80
War	82

BLUFFING	85
BS	85
CASINO	88
Blackjack	88

SOLITAIRE (1 PLAYER)

FreeCell

Also known as	Free Cell, FreeCell Solitaire
Players	1 player
Deck	1 standard deck (52 cards), jokers removed
Time	10-30 minutes
Difficulty	Easy
Category	Solitaire (1 player)

Setup

Take one 52-card deck without jokers, shuffle it, and deal the whole pack face up into eight tableau columns: seven cards each to the first four columns and six each to the last four. Spread each column so that every card in it stays readable, with the last card of the column fully exposed.

Above or beside the tableau, set out four free cells on one side and four foundation spaces on the other. All eight start empty.

That is the entire layout. There is no stock, no waste and no redeal, and nothing is dealt face down. From the first move to the last you are working with complete information, which is what separates FreeCell from Klondike and Spider. No new card can turn up, so a deal is a puzzle that is already either solvable or not before you touch it.

Play

The foundations are built up in suit from the ace to the king, one foundation per suit. The tableau columns are built down in alternating colours, so a black jack accepts a red 10 and that red 10 accepts a black 9.

Strictly speaking exactly one card moves at a time, and it has to be either the exposed card at the end of a column or a card sitting in a free cell. You can send it to:

- a foundation, if it is the next rank up in that suit;
- a tableau column whose end card is one rank higher and the opposite colour;
- an empty free cell, which holds exactly one card and imposes no other condition;
- an empty column, which accepts any single card at all. Unlike Klondike, empty columns are not reserved for kings, and this is the most powerful resource in the game.

A card parked in a free cell is fully available and can be played out again to a column or a foundation whenever it fits. The only cost of using a cell is that it is no longer free for manoeuvring.

Almost every version lets you drag a whole run at once, which is the supermove, also called a power move. It is not a separate rule. It is shorthand for a run of ordinary single-card moves that the software performs for you: the upper cards of the run get shuffled into free cells and empty columns, the bottom card is moved, and the run is rebuilt on top of it. The number of cards you can shift this way is therefore capped by the workspace you have:

maximum cards = (1 + empty free cells) × 2^(empty columns)

With two cells open and no empty columns you can move three cards. With all four cells open and one empty column you can move ten. There is one catch: if the destination is itself an

empty column, that column cannot double as workspace, so leave it out of the exponent. Moving into your only empty column with all four cells free gets you five cards, not ten.

The run you are moving must already be a proper descending, alternating-colour sequence. A stack that merely sits together is not movable as a block, and if you do not have the storage for the whole run you have to break it up by hand.

Taking a card back off a foundation into the tableau is allowed in most implementations and is occasionally the move that saves a deal, but some versions lock a foundation once a card is played there, so check before you count on it.

The deal ends when all four foundations reach their kings, or when you are stuck: every free cell occupied, no empty column, and no exposed card that fits anywhere.

Goal & scoring

You win by moving all 52 cards onto the foundations, each suit in order from ace up to king. FreeCell keeps no points in its traditional form. A deal is won or lost, and players who want a finer measure compare move counts or elapsed time on the same numbered deal rather than tallying a score.

The interesting number in FreeCell is how often a deal can be won at all. Because every card is visible and four cells is a generous allowance, nearly every deal has a solution: solvers put it at roughly 99.999 percent of random deals. Microsoft's original set of 32,000 numbered deals contains exactly one that has been proven impossible, deal 11,982, and establishing that took a volunteer effort running through the mid-1990s. When the same generator was extended to a million deals, only eight unwinnable ones turned up in total: 11,982, 146,692, 186,216, 455,889, 495,505, 512,118, 517,776 and 781,948.

Losing a FreeCell deal is therefore almost always your mistake rather than the shuffle's, which is both the appeal and the cruelty of the game. Solvable does not mean easy, though. Deals 617 and 1,941 from the original set are notorious, and 1,941 is widely nominated as the hardest solvable deal among the 32,000. Working through the numbered deals in order is a long-running informal challenge.

Variants

Baker's Game — The game FreeCell was derived from. Identical layout and identical four free cells, but the tableau builds down in suit instead of alternating colours. Removing colour-based landing spots roughly halves the places any card can go, and winnability drops from near-certainty to somewhere around three quarters of deals, so a lost game here is much less likely to be your fault.

Eight Off — Eight free cells rather than four. Deal 48 cards into eight columns of six, then place the remaining four cards one each into four of the eight cells, leaving four cells open. The tableau builds down in suit, and only a king may be moved into an empty column. The extra cells are compensation for both of those tighter restrictions.

Seahaven Towers — Fifty cards go into ten columns of five, and the last two cards are placed into two of the four free cells, leaving two open. The tableau builds down in suit and only kings may fill an empty column. With ten short columns, two occupied cells and no colour alternation, it plays much more tightly than FreeCell and rewards planning several moves ahead.

ForeCell — Deal four cards face up into the four free cells first, then 48 cards into eight columns of six. You start with every cell full, so your first job is emptying them. The tableau

builds down in alternating colours as in FreeCell, but only a king may be moved into an empty column, which removes the escape hatch that makes standard FreeCell so forgiving.

Rules verified against: Wikipedia, Solitaire Laboratory, Solitaire Central, BVS Solitaire, PlayFreeCellOnline, Freecell Solver documentation (Shlomi Fish). Original text; not reproduced from those sources.

Golf

Also known as	Golf Solitaire, Golf Patience, One Foundation
Players	1 player
Deck	1 standard deck (52 cards)
Time	5-15 minutes
Difficulty	Simple
Category	Solitaire (1 player)

Setup

Shuffle a full 52-card deck. Deal 35 cards face up into seven columns of five. Overlap the cards in each column so every rank stays readable, with the last card dealt to a column sitting at the exposed end. All 35 are visible from the start, so nothing is hidden. The 17 cards left over become the stock, kept face down in a single pile. Turn the top stock card face up beside it to start the waste pile, which is the one pile you will build on for the rest of the deal, leaving 16 cards in the stock. Many descriptions call that build pile the foundation, which is where the alternative name One Foundation comes from, and several of them treat turning the first card as the player's opening move rather than part of the deal. Nothing hangs on that except whether you call the stock 17 or 16 at the moment play begins. Leave room for the waste to grow, since in a good deal nearly the whole pack ends up there. There are no foundations by suit and no reserve; the seven columns, the stock, and the waste are the entire layout.

Play

Only the exposed card at the open end of each column is in play. The rest are locked until the cards covering them are gone.

On your turn you may move any one exposed column card onto the waste pile, provided its rank is exactly one higher or one lower than the current top card of the waste. Suits and colours are ignored entirely. If the waste shows a 9, you may play any 8 or any 10. Moving a card exposes the one behind it in that column, which may then be playable in turn, so a single well-placed card can start a long chain.

Ranks do not wrap in the standard game. Aces are low and kings are high: only a 2 plays onto an ace, and only a queen plays onto a king. Playing an ace on a king, or a king on an ace, is illegal. This is the single rule that ends most deals, and the most commonly relaxed one. A harsher version appears in some rule sets: there a king is a complete dead end and nothing whatever may be packed on it, not even a queen, so a king on the waste forces you to draw. Settle which of the two you are using before you deal, because the difference is large.

You may keep making legal moves for as long as you like; you are never forced to draw. Cards never move between columns, never move back off the waste, and never go onto the stock. Once a column is emptied the gap stays empty for the rest of the deal, and nothing may be placed there.

When you are stuck, or simply choose to, turn the next card of the stock face up onto the waste. That card becomes the new build card regardless of what it covers, so a draw can reset the sequence to any rank. Drawing is the only way to change the top of the waste other than playing a column card.

The deal ends when the stock is empty and no exposed column card can legally be played onto

the waste. There is no redeal and no shuffling of the waste back into the stock. If you have cleared all 35 column cards you have holed out; otherwise the deal is over with cards still on the table.

A separate multiplayer game is also called Golf. That one is usually played as Six-Card Golf, where each player manages a private face-down grid, swapping and discarding to reach the lowest total over nine deals. The two games share only the golf scoring metaphor and are otherwise unrelated; the rules here are for the single-player patience.

Goal & scoring

The object of a single deal is to clear all 35 cards out of the seven columns and onto the waste. Cards left in the stock do not matter.

Score as in golf: count one stroke for every card still stranded in the columns when the deal ends. Clearing the tableau scores zero for the hole, and a common house rule lets you go under par by subtracting one for each card still face down in the stock when you hole out.

A full round is nine deals, one per hole, with the strokes added up, and two rounds of nine make an eighteen-hole match. No authority sets a par for this, so the targets players quote are convention rather than rule; the figure in general circulation is 45 strokes for nine holes, with a total in the mid-thirties counting as a good round. Under strict no-wraparound rules most deals cannot be cleared at all, so a nine-hole total of zero is not a realistic goal.

Variants

Putt Putt (wraparound) — Ranks wrap, so a king may be played on an ace and an ace on a king, making the sequence a continuous loop. This removes the dead ends that spoil most strict deals and lifts the win rate dramatically, which is why nearly every computer version offers it as an easy mode.

Relaxed stock — Allow one redeal: gather the waste after the stock runs out, turn it over without shuffling, and use it as a fresh stock. Some house rules instead let you undo the last move or deal a shorter tableau of six columns of five, leaving 22 cards in the stock. All of these trade difficulty for a better chance of holing out.

Black Hole — David Parlett's rework. Deal 17 fans of three cards around the ace of spades, which sits alone in the centre as the only foundation. Build up or down on it with wraparound, taking the exposed card of any fan, and there is no stock at all. Everything is visible from the start, so it plays as a puzzle rather than a gamble, and the great majority of deals are solvable.

All in a Row — Also by Parlett. The whole deck is dealt into 13 overlapping fans of four cards in a single row, with no stock and no starting foundation card. The first card you take becomes the base of the waste and you build up or down with wraparound from there, aiming to absorb all 52 cards.

Double Golf — Two shuffled decks, 104 cards, dealt into a wider tableau. No layout is standard across sources, so fix one before you deal: eight columns of eight uses 64 cards and leaves 40 in the stock, which keeps the ratio of tableau to stock close to the single-deck game. Everything else, including scoring one stroke per card stranded in the columns, is unchanged. Duplicated ranks give more branching options, but the larger layout means a single dead run can still leave a heavy score.

Rules verified against: Wikipedia, Solitaire Central Rulebook, Solitaire Laboratory, Wikibooks Solitaire card games, Parlett Games, Bicycle Cards. Original text; not reproduced from those sources.

Klondike

Also known as	Solitaire, Patience, Klondike Solitaire, Canfield
Players	1 player
Deck	1 standard deck (52 cards), jokers removed
Time	5-20 minutes
Difficulty	Easy
Category	Solitaire (1 player)

Setup

Use a single 52-card deck with the jokers removed. Shuffle, then build seven tableau piles from left to right: one card in the first pile, two in the second, on up to seven in the seventh, for 28 cards in total. The tidy way to deal it is one card to each pile in a left-to-right sweep, skipping any pile that already holds its full count. Turn the exposed card of every pile face up and leave everything under it face down.

Above the tableau, reserve four spaces for the foundations. They start empty. The 24 cards you did not deal go face down in a single packet as the stock, with an empty space beside it for the waste. There is no dealer to choose and no opponent, so play begins the moment the layout is built.

Play

There are two places to build. The four foundations go up in suit starting from the ace: move an ace up as soon as one is exposed, then the 2 of that suit, and so on through the king. The seven tableau piles go down in alternating colours, so a red 9 accepts a black 8, and that black 8 accepts a red 7.

Playable cards are the exposed card at the outer end of each tableau pile and the top card of the waste. You may move one of those to a foundation, or to a tableau pile whose exposed card is one rank higher and the opposite colour. You may also lift a properly ordered run of face-up tableau cards and move it as a unit onto a card that continues the sequence. Most rule sets let you take just the lower portion of a run; stricter ones make you move the whole face-up group or nothing.

Any time a move leaves a face-down card at the end of a tableau pile, turn it up immediately.

Empty columns carry the one real restriction: only a king, or a run headed by a king, may be moved into a column you have cleared. Nothing else may go there, so emptying a column with no king in sight usually wastes the space.

When you run out of tableau moves, work the stock. Turn cards face up onto the waste and play from there. Only the top card of the waste is ever playable, and it leaves one card at a time. How many cards you turn per go is the setting that defines the two common versions.

Draw one: turn a single card at a time. Every card in the stock reaches the top of the waste on every pass, so nothing stays out of reach and the game is far more forgiving.

Draw three: turn three at once, overlapped so you can read all three but only the outermost is playable. The two behind it become available only after the card in front of them is played. Because the stock is consumed in blocks of three, roughly two thirds of it is unreachable at any given moment, and every card you take shifts which cards surface on the next pass. This is the older and harder default.

When the stock runs out, turn the waste over without shuffling to form a new stock. That is a redeal, and its limit is the other point players argue about. Casual play generally allows unlimited redeals in both draw modes. Scored and timed versions cap it: three passes through the stock, meaning two redeals, is the usual draw-three convention, while draw one and Vegas scoring are often played with a single pass and no redeal at all. Settle the limit before you deal.

Taking the top card back off a foundation into the tableau is permitted in most rule sets and is sometimes the only way to free a card you need, though scored versions charge you for it and a few rule sets forbid it outright.

The deal ends when all four foundations are complete, or when you are stuck: nothing playable from any tableau pile, nothing playable off the waste, and no redeal left.

Goal & scoring

You win by getting all 52 cards onto the foundations, each suit built ace through king. Most people simply play win or lose and keep no score.

Standard scoring, the system most software uses, awards 5 points for moving a card from the waste to the tableau, 10 for moving a card to a foundation, and 5 for turning up a face-down tableau card. Pulling a card back from a foundation costs 15. Recycling the stock costs points once you are past the first pass, commonly 20 in draw three and a steeper charge in draw one, where an extra pass is worth much more. Timed play adds a bonus that grows the faster you finish.

Vegas scoring treats the deal as a wager. You buy the deck for 52 units, one per card, and collect 5 units for every card you land on a foundation, so eleven cards puts you 3 ahead and break-even is closer than it looks. You normally get one pass through the stock, and many players carry a running bankroll from deal to deal.

Klondike is not always winnable, which matters more than beginners expect. Exhaustive computer analysis of draw-three Klondike with every face-down card revealed in advance puts the ceiling at about 82 percent of deals, so roughly one deal in six cannot be won by anyone regardless of skill. Draw one is more winnable than that. Playing blind, as you actually do, real results are much lower: large samples of players come in near a third of games at draw one and around one game in ten at draw three.

Variants

Vegas Klondike — Klondike played as a bet. You pay 52 units for the deck, one per card, and earn 5 units for each card you get onto a foundation, so eleven cards is break-even plus a little. Only one pass through the stock is allowed, with no redeal, which makes the draw-three version brutal. Many players keep a cumulative bankroll across a session instead of settling each deal separately.

Thoughtful Klondike — Identical to ordinary Klondike except that the identity of every face-down card is known from the start. It is mostly a research construct: because the only difference is information, any deal solvable in Thoughtful Klondike is solvable in Klondike too, so solving it gives an upper bound on how often the real game can be won. This is where the roughly 82 percent figure for draw three comes from.

Double Klondike — Two decks, 104 cards, nine tableau piles dealt one through nine, and eight foundations, two per suit. Building rules are unchanged: foundations up in suit from the ace, tableau down in alternating colours, kings only into empty columns. The extra piles make it

noticeably easier to win than single-deck Klondike. The name is also used for a two-player race in which each player has their own tableau but both feed a shared set of foundations.

Whitehead — The same 28-card, seven-pile layout as Klondike, but everything is dealt face up so there is nothing hidden. The tableau builds down in matching colour rather than alternating colour, red on red and black on black. Only runs that are entirely of one suit may be moved as a block, and an empty column will take any card or run, not just a king.

Rules verified against: Wikipedia, Solitaire Laboratory, GameRules.com, Solitaired, Solitaire.com, BVS Solitaire, Solitaire winnability study (Blake and Gent). Original text; not reproduced from those sources.

Pyramid

Also known as	Pyramid Solitaire, Solitaire Thirteen, Pile of Twenty-Eight
Players	1 player
Deck	1 standard deck (52 cards)
Time	5-15 minutes
Difficulty	Easy
Category	Solitaire (1 player)

Setup

Shuffle a full 52-card deck and build the pyramid face up in seven rows. Lay one card at the top, then two below it, then three, and so on down to a bottom row of seven, for 28 cards in all. Offset each row so that every card rests on and partly covers the two cards above it, and so that each card in turn is partly covered by the two below it. Only the seven cards of the bottom row start out completely uncovered.

The remaining 24 cards form the stock, squared up face down to one side. Leave space next to it for a waste pile and space somewhere clear for discards. Ranks count as numbers throughout: ace is 1, jack is 11, queen is 12, king is 13, and every other card is its face value. Suit and colour never matter.

Play

A card is available only when nothing overlaps it. In the pyramid that means both cards below it have already been removed. The bottom row is available from the start; each removal frees the cards above once their other supporter also goes.

Remove available cards in pairs that add to exactly 13. The pairings are ace with queen, 2 with jack, 3 with 10, 4 with 9, 5 with 8, and 6 with 7. Kings are worth 13 on their own, so any available king is removed by itself at any time. That holds wherever the king is: an uncovered king in the pyramid and a king sitting on top of the waste can each be discarded singly. Removed cards are set aside for good and never come back into play.

Both cards of a pair must be available at the moment you take them, but they need not be in the same place. You may pair two uncovered pyramid cards, or one pyramid card with the top card of the waste. Two pyramid cards that sit side by side in the same row can be paired normally, since neither covers the other. What you cannot do is use a card that is still covered, however visible its rank is.

When you want a new card, turn the top card of the stock face up onto the waste. Only the top of the waste is live; the cards under it are buried until it is played. Play the turned card immediately if you can, or leave it and turn another. The card you just turned may be paired with the previous top of the waste, so two consecutive stock cards summing to 13 clear each other.

Draw at your own pace, and take any legal removal at any time. Nothing is ever compulsory: you may decline a pair that is sitting right in front of you, and deliberately leaving one card of a matched pair in place to save a rank for later is a standard tactic, as is holding a convenient card on top of the waste while you work through the pyramid. Equally, there is no obligation to draw while useful pairings remain on the table.

The strict traditional rule gives you a single pass through the stock and no redeal, and that is what this entry assumes. Sources genuinely differ here and most computer versions default to three passes instead, so agree a number before you deal. The deal ends when the stock is exhausted and no further pair can be removed. Since a card buried in the waste is gone for the rest of the deal under those rules, the order in which you spend stock cards matters more than anything else you do.

Goal & scoring

You win by dismantling the whole pyramid: all 28 cards removed. Cards left in the stock or waste are ignored, so clearing the last pyramid card wins immediately even with a stack of unused cards beside you.

The traditional game keeps no score beyond won or lost. Under the strict single-pass rules a clear is genuinely uncommon, and a great many deals are unwinnable no matter how well you play, so judging yourself on wins per session is fairer than judging a single deal.

If you want a score, the usual convention is a penalty of one point per card left in the pyramid, tallied over several deals with the lowest total best. Computer versions often add time bonuses and streak bonuses on top, which is a house scoring layer rather than part of the game.

Variants

Three passes — After the stock runs out, turn the waste over without shuffling to make a new stock and go again. Two redeals, for three passes in total, is the most common relaxed setting and the one most computer versions default to. It rescues cards buried early in the first pass and raises the win rate substantially.

Draw three — Turn stock cards three at a time instead of one, with only the top of each triple available, and allow unlimited redeals to compensate. Sold as King Tut or Tut's Tomb in various solitaire collections. Buried cards become reachable eventually, but you have far less control over which card is showing at any given moment.

Giza — An open variant by Michael Keller. The pyramid is dealt as usual, but the 24 leftover cards go face up into eight piles of three instead of a face-down stock, with the top card of each pile available. Nothing is hidden and there is no drawing, so the deal is a pure planning puzzle that you either solve or do not.

Apophis — Deal the standard 28-card pyramid, then run the stock into three separate waste piles instead of one, choosing which pile each turned card goes on. The top card of all three piles is available at once, which gives you three live cards to work with and much better control over what you keep in reach.

Clear everything — A harder scoring condition rather than a different layout: you must remove all 52 cards, stock and waste included, not just the pyramid. Very few deals can be beaten this way, so it is best treated as an occasional challenge rather than the default.

Rules verified against: Wikipedia, Solitaire Central Rulebook, Wikibooks Solitaire card games, BVS Solitaire, Bicycle Cards, PlayingCardDecks. Original text; not reproduced from those sources.

Spider

Also known as	Spider Solitaire, Spider Patience
Players	1 player
Deck	2 standard decks (104 cards); the easier settings replace the pack with repeated copies of one or two suits
Time	20-45 minutes
Difficulty	Easy
Category	Solitaire (1 player)

Setup

Spider is played with 104 cards, the equivalent of two standard decks. Which suits those cards come from is the difficulty setting. The four-suit game uses two full decks, two of each suit. The two-suit game uses four copies each of two suits, usually spades and hearts. The one-suit game uses eight copies of a single suit. With real cards you are effectively playing four-suit unless you go to the trouble of assembling a stripped pack, which is why the easier settings are mainly a computer thing.

Shuffle all 104 cards together and deal 54 of them into ten tableau columns: six cards each to the first four columns and five cards each to the remaining six. Deal them face down, then turn the exposed card of each column face up. The 50 cards left over become the stock, set aside face down. It will feed the tableau in five deals of ten.

There are no foundation piles to build on. Just leave a clear area beside the tableau for completed sequences, which come off the table intact. You will need room for eight of them.

Play

Everything happens in the tableau. Build columns downward by rank, and by rank alone: any 9 may be placed on any 10 whatever the suits. Aces are low and kings are high, so nothing can ever be placed on an ace, and a king can never be placed on another card.

Suit matters for moving, not for placing. You may always move the single exposed card at the end of a column. You may move several cards as a block only if they run in descending order and are all of the same suit. The 8, 7 and 6 of clubs travel together; a stack of club 8, heart 7, club 6 is a perfectly legal arrangement on the table but has to be taken apart one card at a time. That single restriction is what makes the multi-suit games hard, and it is the rule newcomers most often get wrong.

When a move uncovers a face-down card at the end of a column, turn it face up at once.

An empty column will accept any card, or any block you are allowed to move. Nothing is reserved for kings. Putting a king there is usually the strongest use of the space, though, since a column headed by a low card can only ever take a few more cards on top.

When you have no move worth making, deal from the stock: one card face up onto the end of every one of the ten columns, all at once. You may do this five times, which exactly exhausts the 50-card stock. There is one hard condition attached. Every column must contain at least one card before you deal. If any column is empty you cannot deal, and you have to fill it first, even with a single junk card. Players regularly lose games by clearing a column and then discovering they have locked themselves out of the stock, so plan the deal before you empty anything. Note also that a deal drops a card onto every column whether it helps or not, so it will usually bury

runs you were part way through assembling.

Whenever a full descending same-suit sequence from king down to ace sits at the end of a column, it is removed from the table and set aside. That sequence is finished and can never be touched again. Removing it exposes whatever was underneath, which is very often the real reason you built it.

The game ends when you have removed all eight sequences, or when the stock is empty and no remaining move gets you any closer.

Goal & scoring

You win by assembling and removing all eight complete king-to-ace sequences, each one entirely in a single suit, which clears every card off the table. Anything short of eight is a loss; there is no partial credit in casual play.

The scoring system carried by most software starts you at 500 points and takes off 1 point for every move you make, counting deals from the stock and counting undos. Each completed sequence you remove adds 100. A perfect game is therefore bounded above by 1,300, and real scores land well below that, since even efficient play burns hundreds of moves.

Not every deal can be won, and the suit setting changes the odds enormously. One-suit Spider is winnable nearly every time with careful play, with competent players reporting rates around 90 percent and higher. Two-suit is a real puzzle, with skilled play landing somewhere in the 30 to 40 percent range. Four-suit is the serious version: strong players usually win well under 20 percent of deals, and casual averages sit in the single digits. Unlike FreeCell, Spider has no authoritative exhaustive solvability study, so these numbers come from large samples of actual play rather than from solvers, and you should treat them as ballpark figures.

Variants

Spiderette — One deck, Klondike-shaped. Deal 28 cards into seven columns of one through seven, exposed card face up, and keep the other 24 as stock. Building, group movement and sequence removal follow Spider exactly, but you only need four king-to-ace suit sequences. The stock is dealt seven at a time, one card onto each column, and the last deal is short: three cards, going to the leftmost columns.

Will o' the Wisp — A faster one-deck Spider. Deal seven columns of three cards each, 21 in total, with only the exposed card of each column face up. The remaining 31 cards feed the tableau seven at a time. Everything else matches Spider, and four suit sequences win it. The shallow columns mean far less is hidden at the start, which makes it markedly kinder than Spiderette.

Black Widow — Spider with the group-move restriction dropped. Same two decks, same ten columns of six, six, five, and same five deals of ten from the stock, but any descending run may be picked up and moved as a block regardless of suit. Sequences still have to be all one suit to be removed, so the goal is unchanged. Removing the hardest rule in Spider makes this the easiest game in the family.

Simple Simon — One deck, no stock, nothing hidden. All 52 cards go face up into ten columns of eight, eight, eight, seven, six, five, four, three, two and one. Build down by rank ignoring suit, move blocks only when they are same-suit descending runs, and put any card into an empty column. Remove the four king-to-ace suit sequences to win. With no stock and full information it is a pure puzzle rather than a game of chance.

Rules verified against: Wikipedia, Semicolon Solitaire Rules, Solitaired, BVS Solitaire, SuitedGames, TrySolitaire, Solitaire Bliss. Original text; not reproduced from those sources.

TRICK-TAKING

Euchre

Also known as	Eucre, Euker
Players	3-6 players (best with 4)
Deck	1 standard deck stripped to 24 cards (A, K, Q, J, 10, 9 in each suit)
Time	20-40 minutes
Difficulty	Easy
Category	Trick-taking

Setup

Four players in two fixed partnerships, partners seated opposite each other. Strip a standard pack down to 24 cards: ace, king, queen, jack, ten and nine in each of the four suits. Nothing lower is used.

For the first dealer, turn cards face up one at a time around the table and give the deal to whoever receives the first black jack. After that the deal passes clockwise every hand.

Deal five cards to each player clockwise in two rounds, three to a player then two, or two then three. Whichever pattern you start with, keep it for the rest of that deal. That accounts for twenty cards. Stack the remaining four face down in the middle as the kitty and turn its top card face up. That upcard is the suit on offer in the first round of bidding.

Do not sort your hand yet, because ranking is not fixed until trump is settled. In the three plain suits cards run ace, king, queen, jack, ten, nine from high to low. In trump the order is right bower (the jack of the trump suit, the best card in the deck), left bower (the other jack of the same color), then ace, king, queen, ten, nine. The left bower does not merely rank as trump, it belongs to trump for the whole hand. With spades as trump the jack of clubs is a spade: you may not use it to follow a club lead, and you must play it to a spade lead if it is your only spade. The trump suit therefore holds seven cards and the same-color suit only five.

Keep score on paper, or with the traditional pair of spare low cards laid face down and turned to show the count.

Play

First round of bidding. Beginning with the player to the dealer's left and moving clockwise, each player either passes or accepts the upcard's suit as trump. Accepting is called ordering it up if you are one of the dealer's opponents, assisting if you are the dealer's partner, and taking it up if you are the dealer. As soon as somebody accepts, bidding stops: the dealer adds the upcard to hand and buries any one card face down under the kitty, going back to five cards. The side that chose trump are the makers, the other pair the defenders.

Second round of bidding. If all four pass, the dealer turns the upcard face down on the kitty and the auction goes round once more from the dealer's left. Now a player may pass or name any suit as trump except the suit just turned down. Naming the other suit of the same color is called next; naming either suit of the opposite color is cross, or green. Nobody exchanges cards in the second round, and the kitty is finished with. If all four pass again the hand is dead: throw the cards in and pass the deal. Under the very common stick-the-dealer rule the dealer is instead forced to name a suit rather than let the hand die.

Going alone. Whoever names trump, in either round, may declare a loner at that moment, before any card is led. Their partner lays all five cards face down and takes no part in the hand, and the maker plays one against two. The declaration must be made when trump is called; you cannot decide to go alone once play has started.

Playing the tricks. The player to the dealer's left leads to the first trick, except on a loner, where the lead falls to the player on the loner's left. Each player in turn clockwise must follow the suit led if holding a card of it. A player who cannot follow may play anything at all, trump included. There is no obligation to trump and no obligation to beat what has already been played. The trick goes to the highest trump in it, or, if nobody trumped, to the highest card of the suit led. The winner of a trick leads to the next. Five tricks are played and the hand is then scored.

The bower trap. Two situations catch new players, and both come from the left bower changing suit. If hearts are trump and a diamond is led, the jack of diamonds is a heart and may not be played to follow the diamond lead. If hearts are trump and hearts are led, a player whose only heart is the jack of diamonds does hold a heart and must play it.

Reneging. Failing to follow suit when you were able to is a renege. Standard club and tournament practice is to stop the hand as soon as it is discovered and award the innocent side 2 points, or 4 if the renege was committed against a lone hand.

Four of the twenty-four cards never reach a hand, so besides the upcard three cards stay unknown all deal. That, along with the dealer's buried discard, is what makes tracking the seven trump cards worth the effort.

Goal & scoring

A side wins by being first to 10 points. Points come only from the outcome of a hand; individual tricks are worth nothing on their own, and the defenders score nothing at all whenever the makers succeed.

Score at the end of each hand as follows:

- Makers win three or four tricks: 1 point.
- Makers win all five, called a march: 2 points.
- A lone maker wins three or four tricks: 1 point.
- A lone maker wins all five: 4 points.
- Makers win fewer than three tricks: they are euchred, and the defenders take 2 points.

Note the asymmetry on a loner. Success pays two extra points, failure costs nothing extra, since a euchre is worth 2 to the defenders whether or not the maker went alone. Note also that ordering up hands the makers all the risk: a euchre is worth as much as a march, which is why a side sitting on 8 or 9 points is dangerous to bid against.

Games are usually a race to 10. Playing to 11 is common in some regions, and league play sometimes uses a fixed number of hands with the higher total winning instead of a target score.

Variants

Stick the dealer — Also called screw the dealer. If the first three players pass in the second round of bidding, the dealer may not pass and must name one of the three eligible suits. It removes thrown-in hands entirely, speeds the game up, and creates the game's most reliable pressure point, since the dealer is often forced into a suit they would never have called voluntarily. Widespread enough that many tables treat it as standard rather than a variation.

Cutthroat (three-handed) Euchre — Three players, no partnerships, same 24-card deck and same five-card hands, with the remainder forming the kitty and its top card turned up. Whoever names trump plays alone against the other two, who cooperate for that hand only. The maker scores 1 point for three or four tricks and 3 points for all five; if the maker is euchred, each of the two defenders scores 2. First to 10 wins. The temporary alliances make it a very different bidding game from the partnership version.

The Benny (25-card Euchre) — A joker, sometimes replaced by the two of spades, is added to the deck as the Benny or best bower: the highest trump no matter which suit is trump. Holding it guarantees a trick. If the Benny is turned up as the upcard, the dealer names the trump suit. Common in Britain, Australia and parts of Canada, often alongside a target of 11 points rather than 10.

Bid Euchre — An auction version, usually with a larger deck (frequently 24 or 32 cards, or two packs combined for more players), in which players bid a specific number of tricks rather than simply accepting or naming trump. The high bidder names trump, and scoring is by tricks won rather than by the fixed 1, 2 and 4 point table. A side that fails to reach its bid loses points equal to the bid. It scales to five and six players more comfortably than standard Euchre.

Defending alone — An optional rule allowing a defender to announce that they will play alone against a lone maker, sending their own partner out of the hand as well and turning it into a one-against-one duel. If the defender euchres the maker, their side scores 4 instead of 2. High variance, and worth agreeing on before the first deal, since not every group plays it.

Rules verified against: Pagat, Bicycle Cards, Wikipedia, Britannica, World Euchre Federation, Ohio Euchre, Trickster Cards. Original text; not reproduced from those sources.

Hearts

Also known as	Black Lady, Chase the Lady, Black Widow
Players	3-6 players (best with 4)
Deck	1 standard deck (52 cards), jokers removed; a few low cards come out for 3, 5 or 6 players
Time	30-60 minutes
Difficulty	Easy
Category	Trick-taking

Setup

Hearts is at its best with four players, each on their own. There are no partnerships and no trump suit. Use a 52-card pack with the jokers taken out. Aces are high and twos are low in every suit.

Pick a first dealer however you like, drawing for the low card being the usual method, then pass the deal one seat to the left after every hand. The dealer shuffles and deals the entire pack out one card at a time, clockwise, beginning with the player on their left. Four players get 13 cards each and the hand runs 13 tricks.

Other numbers need the pack trimmed so the deal comes out even. For three players, remove the 2 of diamonds and deal 17 each. For five, remove the 2 of diamonds and the 2 of clubs and deal 10 each. For six, remove the 2 of diamonds, the 2 and 3 of clubs and the 2 of spades and deal 8 each. The cards pulled are always low cards from the two suits that carry no penalties, so nothing about the scoring changes.

There is no layout, no stock and no discard pile. Everything sits in the players' hands, and there is nothing to write down until the first hand has been played out.

Play

Every hand opens with a pass. Pick three cards out of your hand and lay them face down in front of the player who is to receive them. Nobody may look at the cards coming their way until they have committed their own three, so the exchange is genuinely blind on both sides. The direction rotates deal by deal: pass to the left on the first hand, to the right on the second, straight across on the third, and on the fourth hand nobody passes at all and you play what you were dealt. Then the cycle starts again. Three players have no seat across from anyone, so their rotation is left, right, hold.

Once the passes have been picked up, whoever holds the 2 of clubs must lead it to the first trick. If the 2 of clubs was removed for the player count, the lowest club still in the pack leads instead: the 3 of clubs in a five-handed game, the 4 of clubs in a six-handed game. Play then goes clockwise, one card from each player.

You must follow the suit led if you hold anything in it. Only when you are void may you play something else, and then you may play any card you like subject to the two restrictions below. Because there is no trump suit, a trick is simply won by the highest card of the suit that was led. A card thrown off-suit cannot win the trick no matter how high it is. The winner gathers the trick face down and leads to the next one.

Two restrictions shape the whole hand.

First trick. No penalty card may be thrown on the opening trick. That rules out every heart and the queen of spades, even if you are void in clubs and would love to be rid of them. The only escape is a hand that contains literally nothing else, which almost never happens. Some groups relax this to bar hearts only and allow the queen on the first trick, so settle it before you deal.

Leading hearts. You may not lead a heart until hearts have been broken, and they are broken the first time somebody discards a heart on a trick led in another suit. The one exception is a player whose remaining cards are all hearts; they may lead one. The queen of spades is under no such restriction. She can be played whenever spades are led and discarded whenever you are void, and in the standard game putting her down does not break hearts. A good number of tables play that she does break them, which is worth agreeing on in advance.

A hand ends when all the cards are gone. Everyone turns their tricks face up, counts the penalty cards inside them, and the results go on the score sheet before the next player deals.

Goal & scoring

Hearts is a game you are trying to lose. The winner is whoever holds the fewest penalty points when the game ends.

Each heart you collect in a trick costs 1 penalty point and the queen of spades costs 13, so exactly 26 points are distributed every deal. Nothing else scores at all. The number of tricks you win is irrelevant; only what is inside them matters.

The exception is shooting the moon. If a single player takes all 13 hearts and the queen of spades in the same hand, the result inverts: the shooter scores nothing and every opponent is charged 26. Most groups let the shooter choose instead to subtract 26 from their own total, which is the better option when the opponents are already close to the finish or when you are sitting on zero and cannot go below it. The attempt is all or nothing. Let one heart escape to another player and you simply keep the pile you have gathered, which is normally a catastrophe.

Keep a running total for each player. The game ends at the end of the hand in which anyone reaches or passes 100 points, and the player with the lowest total at that moment wins. A target of 50 makes for a quicker game. If the two lowest totals are level, the usual fix is to keep dealing until the tie breaks.

Variants

Omnibus Hearts (Jack of Diamonds) — The jack of diamonds becomes a bonus card worth minus 10, so whoever takes it in a trick has 10 points struck off their score for that hand. It reshapes the deal completely, because diamonds are suddenly worth fighting for rather than dumping, and a shot at the moon now requires the jack as well as all the hearts and the queen of spades. Some groups use the 10 of diamonds for the same purpose.

Black Maria — The British three-handed form. Take out the 2 of clubs so that each of three players receives 17 cards. Three spades carry penalties instead of one: the queen is worth 13, the king 10 and the ace 7. Cards are passed three to the right only, there is no fixed opening lead, and many groups play it without any moon-shooting rule, so the hand is purely about dodging the black suit.

Cancellation Hearts — Built for six or more players using two full packs shuffled together. Identical cards cancel each other: if the same rank and suit appears twice in one trick, neither copy can win it, and the trick goes to the highest surviving card of the suit led. If every candidate cancels out, nobody wins the trick; it stays on the table and is swept up along with all

its penalty cards by whoever takes the next one.

Spot Hearts — Hearts are worth their pip value rather than a flat point each. The 2 through 10 count face value, the jack, queen and king count 10 apiece, the ace counts 15, and the queen of spades is raised to 25. That makes a single deal worth 124 points instead of 26, so the game target has to be scaled up to match, commonly to 500. Low hearts become throwaways and the ace of hearts becomes the card everyone is watching.

Shoot the Sun — An extra tier above shooting the moon that almost nobody achieves. Taking every trick in the hand, not merely every penalty card, is worth double the usual moon: 52 points against each opponent, or 52 struck off your own total, whichever you prefer. Groups that use it treat a failed sun as an ordinary moon attempt, so a player who wins twelve tricks and all the penalties still scores the plain moon.

Rules verified against: Pagat, Bicycle Cards, Wikipedia, Britannica, Official Game Rules, Dice Game Depot, Trickster Cards, Cool Old Games. Original text; not reproduced from those sources.

Oh Hell

Also known as	Oh Pshaw, Blackout, Nomination Whist, Contract Whist, Up and Down the River, Elevator, Bust
Players	3-7 players (best with 5)
Deck	1 standard deck (52 cards)
Time	30-60 minutes
Difficulty	Easy
Category	Trick-taking

Setup

Three to seven players, everyone for themselves, with one standard 52-card deck. Aces are high, there are no partnerships, and the game plays best with four to six.

A game is a fixed series of deals in which the hand size changes every time. The most common shape is an arc: start at the largest hand you have agreed on, drop one card per deal down to a single card, then climb back up to where you started. With five players starting at ten, that is 10, 9, 8 and so on down to 1, then 2, 3 up to 10 again, nineteen deals in total. Other groups run the arc upward only, or downward only, or cut it off at a round number such as seven. Decide the shape and write the sequence at the top of the score sheet before the first card is dealt, because the whole game is scored against it.

The ceiling on hand size is what the deck allows. Divide 52 by the number of players and round down: 17 for three, 13 for four, 10 for five, 8 for six, 7 for seven. Most groups play a shorter arc than the maximum simply to keep the game to a sensible length.

Choose a first dealer at random; the deal then moves clockwise every hand. Deal the agreed number of cards one at a time to each player, then turn the next card of the undealt stock face up. Its suit is trump for that deal. That card belongs to nobody and stays face up beside the remaining stock, which is not used. On a deal that consumes the entire pack there is no card left to turn, so that hand is played with no trump at all.

Rule a grid before you start: one column per player, one row per deal, with space to record each player's bid next to their running total.

Play

Bidding. With the cards dealt and trump turned, each player in turn starting to the dealer's left, and finishing with the dealer, announces out loud exactly how many tricks they intend to win. Bids are spoken in order, not written secretly, so later bidders are better informed than earlier ones. Zero is a legal and frequently correct bid. No bid may exceed the number of cards in the hand.

The hook. The dealer bids last and is the only player under a restriction: the dealer may not name a number that would make the bids add up to exactly the number of tricks available. At least one player is therefore guaranteed to miss. If the hand is five cards and the four earlier bids were 1, 2, 0 and 1, totalling four, the dealer may say anything except 1. This is the rule the game is named for, and it exists to stop a table from politely arranging for everyone to succeed. If the earlier bids already add up to more than the number of tricks, the dealer is unrestricted, since no bid can bring the total back down.

Write every bid on the score sheet before a card is played. Bids cannot be revised once the first lead is made.

The play. The player to the dealer's left leads to the first trick and may lead anything at all, trump included; there is no rule against leading trump early. Going clockwise, each player must follow the suit led if they hold a card of it. A player holding none of the led suit may play any card, trump or otherwise, and is under no obligation either to trump or to try to win. The trick is taken by the highest trump in it, or, if no trump was played, by the highest card of the suit led. The winner of the trick leads to the next. On a no-trump deal the highest card of the suit led always wins.

Keep the tricks you win in your own stack rather than a communal pile, since everyone has to be able to count their own at the end. In long hands it is worth restating bids aloud partway through.

The one-card deal. Each player holds a single card and has no decision to make in the play at all, so the entire hand is the bidding: you are guessing whether your card beats everyone else's. These deals swing the scoreboard hard, and they are the reason the arc bottoms out at one card rather than stopping higher.

When the last trick of a deal has been taken, compare each player's count with their bid, score the hand, gather the cards, and pass the deal one seat clockwise. Play continues until the agreed sequence of deals is exhausted.

Goal & scoring

You win by holding the highest total when the agreed run of deals is finished. There is no target to race to and no sudden-death ending; the game is over when the arc is over.

The standard scoring is all-or-nothing per hand. A player who takes exactly the number of tricks bid scores 10 plus that number, so a made bid of 3 is worth 13 and a made bid of 0 is worth 10. A player who takes any other number scores nothing for that hand. Overtricks earn no consolation whatever: bidding three and taking four is exactly as worthless as bidding three and taking two, which is what makes deliberately dumping a trick on an opponent a real weapon.

A common gentler version awards every player 1 point per trick taken regardless of whether they hit their bid, plus a flat 10-point bonus for hitting it exactly. That keeps trailing players engaged; the strict version produces sharper swings and a tenser endgame. Choose one before the first deal, because the two reward completely different bidding.

A bid of zero is the most dependable score on the sheet, since it pays 10 and requires no cards at all. It is also the hardest thing to defend once someone leads a suit you are void in and you are forced to spend a card that might win.

Ties for first place are normally just shared. Some groups settle them with a single extra one-card deal.

Variants

Alternative scoring schemes — Besides the standard 10 plus bid, two schemes are widespread. The forgiving one gives 1 point per trick taken to everybody plus a 10-point bonus for an exact bid. The punishing one gives 10 plus the square of the bid when you succeed and subtracts the square of the difference when you miss, which makes large bids enormously valuable and near-misses expensive. All three are played under the same name, so ask before you sit down.

No hook (free bidding) — Drop the restriction on the dealer entirely, so the bids may total exactly the number of tricks and every player at the table can theoretically make their contract. The game becomes friendlier and much less cutthroat, since nobody is guaranteed to fail. Some groups compromise by applying the hook only on the smaller hands, where it bites hardest.

Blind one-card deals — On the deal where each player holds one card, nobody looks at their own card. Instead each player holds it face outward against their forehead, so they can see everyone else's card but not their own, and bid on that information. It turns the most luck-heavy deal of the game into a deduction problem and is popular enough that many groups treat it as part of the standard game.

Nomination trump (Contract Whist) — Rather than turning a card for trump, the highest bidder names the trump suit, which is where the alternative name Nomination Whist comes from. Bidding then becomes a genuine auction, since the right to choose trump is worth competing for, and the winning bidder usually leads to the first trick. Some versions of this form also require the first-hand bid to be made before players look at all of their cards.

Deal-pattern variations — The names attached to this game usually track its deal pattern. Up and Down the River and the British Nomination Whist run the full descending-then-ascending arc. Oh Pshaw generally means the ascending-only version, starting at one card and building up. Elevator and Blackout are used for either direction depending on the region. The rules of play are identical in all of them; only the sequence of hand sizes and hence the length of the game changes.

Rules verified against: Pagat, Wikipedia, Trickster Cards, Game Rules, Official Game Rules, PlayingCardDecks.
Original text; not reproduced from those sources.

Pinochle

Also known as	Pinocle, Penuchle, Partnership Auction Pinochle
Players	2-4 players (best with 4)
Deck	1 pinochle deck (48 cards: two each of A, 10, K, Q, J, 9 in every suit), which you can build from two standard decks by keeping only those ranks
Time	45-90 minutes
Difficulty	Complex
Category	Trick-taking

Setup

This entry describes single-deck partnership auction Pinochle: four players, two fixed partnerships, one 48-card pinochle pack. Double-deck partnership Pinochle, which is at least as widely played in North America, is described under variants.

The pack holds two copies of ace, ten, king, queen, jack and nine in each suit, 48 cards in all. Rank within a suit is not what you expect: the ace is high, but the ten sits second, above the king. The full order is A, 10, K, Q, J, 9 from high to low. When two identical cards meet in the same trick, the one played first outranks the copy.

Partners sit opposite each other. Settle the first deal however you like, high cut being usual, then pass the deal clockwise. Shuffle, cut, and deal every card out clockwise in packets of three or four until each player holds twelve. There is no stock and no widow in this version; all 48 cards are in hands from the start.

Rule a score sheet with one column per partnership. Each hand produces a bid, a meld figure and a trick figure for each side before anything is combined, so leave room to write all three rather than only a running total.

Agree two house questions before the first deal, because tables differ and both change how you bid: whether the contracting side exchanges four cards after naming trump, and whether you are playing to 1000 points or some other target.

Play

A hand runs in three stages: the auction, the meld, then twelve tricks.

The auction. Bidding opens with the player to the dealer's left and moves clockwise. A bid is the number of points your side undertakes to score this hand, meld and captured counters combined. The usual minimum opening bid is 250, and each later bid must beat the previous one, normally in steps of 10. Passing puts you out of the auction for that hand, and the auction ends when three players have passed in succession. The last live bidder's side has the contract. If nobody bids at all, most groups oblige the dealer to take the contract at the minimum; some throw the hand in and redeal.

Naming trump and the pass. The high bidder names the trump suit. Many tables then use a four-card pass: the bidder's partner passes four cards face down, the bidder looks at them and passes any four back. The returned cards need not be the ones received. Tables that play without the pass bid noticeably lower, which is why it is worth agreeing on it in advance.

Melding. All four players lay their scoring combinations face up on the table at once. Each side adds its meld aloud, the totals are written down, and the cards are then taken back into hand before any card is played. Meld comes from the cards you hold at that moment, never from

cards captured later in tricks. A single card may be used in more than one meld provided the melds are of different types: the queen of spades can count in a marriage, in a pinochle and in queens around all at once, but one queen of spades cannot form two marriages. The important restriction is that a side scores none of its meld unless it wins at least one trick during the play.

The tricks. The high bidder leads to the first trick and play runs clockwise. The rules for playing a card are strict, which is the feature that separates Pinochle from most trick games:

- If you can follow suit you must, and if you can also beat the highest card of that suit already played, you must do that as well.
- If you cannot follow suit, you must play a trump if you hold one.
- If the trick has already been trumped and you cannot follow suit, you must play a higher trump than the one on the table when you can.
- Only when you can neither follow nor trump may you play whatever you like.

A trick is won by the highest trump in it, or by the highest card of the suit led when no trump has been played. Between two identical cards, the one led or played earlier wins. The winner of a trick leads to the next. When all twelve tricks are gone, the side that took the last trick claims a bonus, both sides count the counters they captured, and the hand is scored.

One consequence of the must-beat rule worth planning for: you cannot quietly duck a trick to protect a ten. If you hold the ace and the ten of a led suit and an opponent's ace is already on the table, you are compelled to play your own ace, and your ten is exposed for the rest of the hand.

Goal & scoring

The counters are the aces, tens and kings. In the point-count scheme most tables now use, each counter captured in a trick is worth 10 to the side that took it, and queens, jacks and nines are worth nothing. Twenty-four counters make 240, and the last trick is worth an extra 10, so exactly 250 points are available in tricks every hand. The older values, still in use, are ace 11, ten 10, king 4, queen 3, jack 2 with 10 for the last trick, which comes to the same 250.

Meld values in the single-deck game:

- Run in trump (A-10-K-Q-J of trump): 150. Both trump runs: 1500.
- Royal marriage, the king and queen of trump: 40.
- Plain marriage, king and queen of any other suit: 20 each.
- Dix, the nine of trump: 10 each, so 20 for the pair.
- Pinochle, the queen of spades with the jack of diamonds: 40. Double pinochle: 300.
- Aces around, one ace of each suit: 100. Double: 1000.
- Kings around: 80. Double: 800.
- Queens around: 60. Double: 600.
- Jacks around: 40. Double: 400.

A run already contains the royal marriage, so you do not also claim the 40 for it.

Settling a hand. Add each side's meld to the counters it captured. If the contracting side reaches or passes its bid, both sides simply add what they made. If it falls short it has gone set: it scores nothing for the hand and the full amount of the bid is subtracted from its running total, which can drive the score below zero. The defending side scores its meld and counters as normal, subject to the same requirement that meld needs at least one trick to stand.

First side to 1000 points wins. The customary tie-break is that the contracting side's score is settled first, so if both sides cross the target in the same hand the contractors win, having taken the risk. Some groups play to 1500, and some let a side stop play mid-hand to claim the game.

Variants

Double-deck partnership Pinochle — Four players in partnerships with an 80-card pack: two pinochle decks combined with all the nines removed, so four copies of A, 10, K, Q and J in each suit. Everyone gets 20 cards. Bidding opens at 50 and rises in steps of one or five. Meld values are roughly a tenth of the single-deck figures, so a trump run is 15, aces around 10, kings around 8, queens around 6, jacks around 4, a royal marriage 4, a plain marriage 2, a pinochle 4 and a double pinochle 30. Counters are the aces, tens and kings at 1 point each, 48 in total, plus 2 for the last trick, giving 50 points in tricks per hand. Game is 500. There is no card pass, and the same must-follow, must-beat, must-trump rules apply. Many North American players regard this as the standard modern form of the game.

Two-handed Pinochle — The classic head-to-head game, and the oldest form. Each player gets 12 cards from the 48-card pack and the remaining 24 form a face-down stock with its top card turned up to set trump. There is no auction. After each trick the winner draws the top card of the stock and the loser takes the next, and the trick winner may lay down one meld before drawing, scoring it immediately. Holding the dix, the nine of trump, lets you swap it for the exposed trump card. Suit-following and must-beat rules do not apply until the stock runs out, at which point the last 12 tricks are played under the strict rules. Game is usually 1000.

Three-handed Auction Pinochle — The best-known solo form, played with the 48-card pack. Each of the three players gets 15 cards and three go face down as a widow. Players bid, minimum usually 300, and the high bidder turns the widow face up, takes it in, names trump, and buries any three cards, which count toward the bidder's own trick score if they are counters. The bidder then plays alone against the other two, who cooperate. The bidder must reach the bid with meld plus counters or be set for the amount bid; the defenders score nothing but the satisfaction of setting the contract, and games are frequently settled per hand in chips rather than by a target total.

Traditional counter values — Instead of counting each ace, ten and king as 10, some tables use the historical values of ace 11, ten 10, king 4, queen 3 and jack 2, with the nine worth nothing and 10 for the last trick. The total available is identical at 250, but the distribution differs, making individual aces and tens relatively more valuable and kings less so. Worth confirming which scheme is in use before bidding, since it slightly shifts what a hand is worth.

Rules verified against: Pagat, Bicycle Cards, Wikipedia, Britannica, Trickster Cards, Denexa Games. Original text; not reproduced from those sources.

Spades

Players	2-4 players (best with 4)
Deck	1 standard deck (52 cards), jokers removed
Time	45-90 minutes
Difficulty	Medium
Category	Trick-taking

Setup

Spades is a four-player partnership game. Partners sit opposite each other so that the two sides alternate around the table. Use a 52-card pack with the jokers taken out. Cards rank ace high down to 2 low in every suit, and spades are permanently trump. Nothing is turned or named to decide the trump suit; it is spades in every hand of every game.

Choose the first dealer by cutting, high card taking the deal, and move the deal one seat to the left after each hand. The dealer shuffles, offers a cut to the player on their right, then deals the whole pack out one card at a time clockwise starting with the player on their left, so everyone finishes with 13 cards. Each hand is therefore 13 tricks.

Set up the score sheet before you start. You need one column per partnership for points and, next to each, a small separate running tally of bags. The bag count carries across the entire game rather than resetting each hand, and forgetting to track it is the single most common way a Spades game goes wrong.

Play

Bidding comes first and takes exactly one round. Starting with the player to the dealer's left and moving clockwise, each player looks at their hand and names the number of tricks they expect to take, anything from 0 to 13. Bids do not have to increase, nobody may pass, and once a number is said it stands. You may not describe your hand or ask your partner anything, but every bid is public, so the last player to bid knows a great deal more than the first. The two partners' bids are added together into a single contract for the side: bids of 4 and 3 mean that partnership must take at least 7 tricks. Some groups impose a minimum team contract of 4, so check the house rule before you deal.

A bid of 0 is nil, a declaration that you personally will win no tricks whatsoever. Your partner bids normally and their number alone becomes the side's trick contract. Nil is scored separately and can succeed or fail independently of whether that contract is made.

Blind nil is a nil declared before you have looked at your cards at all, so it has to be announced as soon as the deal is finished. Most tables permit it only when your side is trailing by at least 100 points. After all four bids are in and before the first lead, the blind nil bidder pushes two cards face down across to their partner, who looks at them and passes two cards back face down. The point is to let the bidder shed two dangerous high cards and take low ones in exchange, while the partner absorbs the strength.

The player to the dealer's left leads to the first trick and may not lead a spade. Play continues clockwise. You must follow the suit led if you can; if you are void you may play any card at all, including a spade. A trick is won by the highest spade played to it, and if no spade was played, by the highest card of the suit led. A card of some third suit never wins. The winner of each trick leads to the next.

Spades may not be led until they have been broken, meaning until some spade has been played to a trick led in another suit, whether that was a deliberate ruff or a helpless discard. The one exception is a player holding nothing but spades, who may lead one. Nothing stops you trumping in the first time you are void; that is normally how spades get broken.

Everyone keeps their side's tricks together where both partnerships can count them. When the thirteenth trick is finished, count the tricks each side took and score the hand, then pass the deal to the left.

Goal & scoring

The first partnership to 500 points wins.

A side that takes at least as many tricks as it bid scores 10 points per trick bid, plus 1 point for each trick beyond the bid. Those extras are bags, also called sandbags, and the single point each one pays now is really a loan against a penalty later. Bid 7 and take 9 and you score 72: seventy for the contract and two for the bags.

A side that falls short is set and loses 10 points per trick bid, with no credit at all for the tricks it did win. Bid 7 and take 6 and you lose 70.

Bags accumulate for the whole game in their own tally. The moment a side reaches 10 bags, 100 points are deducted from that side's score and 10 comes off the bag count, leaving any surplus in place to start the next batch. Games are routinely decided by a sandbag penalty rather than by anything that happened in a trick, which is why deliberately underbidding a strong hand is a losing habit.

A successful nil is worth 100 points to the partnership, on top of whatever the partner's contract scores. A nil that wins even one trick costs 100. Blind nil doubles both numbers to plus or minus 200. When a nil fails, the standard treatment is that tricks won by the nil bidder do not help the partner make their contract but do count as bags for the side. Some groups let those tricks count toward the contract instead, so agree which before you start.

Play continues until a side is at 500 or more at the end of a hand. If both sides cross in the same hand, the higher total wins, and a genuine tie is broken by playing one more hand. Many groups also set a floor of minus 200, at which point that side loses outright.

Variants

Cutthroat (Solo) Spades — Partnerships are abolished and every player bids and scores for themselves, which turns the game into a running series of temporary alliances against whoever is ahead. Nil is usually reduced to 50 or 100 by agreement and the target is shortened, often to 200 or 300. Three-handed cutthroat is common too: remove the 2 of clubs so that 51 cards deal out to 17 each.

Suicide Spades — A partnership variant in which exactly one member of each side must bid nil on every single hand, with the partner carrying the whole trick contract alone and usually held to a minimum of 4. Partners decide between themselves who takes the nil, normally by an agreed signal or simply by whoever bids first. Scores swing enormously and the game becomes almost entirely about protecting a partner's nil.

Whiz and Mirror — Two restricted-bidding forms. In Whiz, each player must bid either nil or the exact number of spades in their hand, and no other bid is legal. Mirror is the stricter cousin: you must bid your spade count, and nil is only available to a player who was dealt no spades at all. Both remove almost all bidding judgement and shift the entire game onto the play of the cards.

Jokers and high deuces — Both jokers are added to the pack as the two highest trumps, a big joker and a little joker, and two low cards are removed so the deal still comes to 13 each. Many groups also promote one or more deuces into the trump suit above the ace of spades. The pecking order among the promoted deuces is the most argued-about detail in the whole game and varies from table to table, so establish it out loud before the first deal rather than mid-trick.

Two-handed Spades — Instead of a deal, the pack sits face down and the players alternate building their hands from it. On your turn you look at the top card and either keep it, in which case the next card goes to the discard pile unseen, or reject it, in which case you must take the card underneath. Continue until each player holds 13 cards; the rest are out of play. Bidding, the ban on leading spades before they are broken, and the scoring are all unchanged, and the game still runs to 500.

Rules verified against: Pagat, Bicycle Cards, Trickster Cards, VIP Spades, Spades.co, DKM Games, MPL Games. Original text; not reproduced from those sources.

Whist

Also known as	Straight Whist, Partnership Whist, English Whist
Players	4 players
Deck	1 standard deck (52 cards), jokers removed
Time	30-60 minutes
Difficulty	Simple
Category	Trick-taking

Setup

Whist is for exactly four players in two fixed partnerships, partners sitting opposite each other. Use a 52-card pack with the jokers taken out. In play the cards rank ace high down to 2 low.

Draw for partners and for the first deal at the same time. Spread the pack face down and have everyone take a card, counting the ace as low for this purpose only. The two lowest cards play against the two highest, and the lowest card of all deals first. Anyone who draws a duplicate rank or the bottom card of the pack draws again. After the first hand the deal moves one seat to the left.

The dealer shuffles, the player to the dealer's right cuts, and the whole pack is dealt out one card at a time clockwise, starting with the player on the dealer's left, so each hand holds 13. The final card of the deal, which belongs to the dealer, is turned face up on the table instead of being tucked into the hand. Its suit is trumps for that hand. It stays face up where everyone can see it until the dealer plays to the first trick, at which point the dealer takes it into hand and it becomes an ordinary card. From that moment on, remembering what it was is your own problem.

There is no bidding, no exchange of cards and no stock. As soon as the trump is turned, play begins.

Play

The player to the dealer's left leads any card at all to the first trick. Play then goes clockwise, one card from each player.

You must follow the suit that was led if you hold a card in it. Only when you are void may you play something else, and then you may play anything: a card of a third suit, which cannot win, or a trump, which can. A trick is taken by the highest trump in it, or if no trump was played, by the highest card of the suit led. The winner of the trick leads to the next one. All thirteen tricks are played out; there is no way to end a hand early, no concession and no discard pile.

How the tricks are stored matters more than beginners expect. One player from each partnership gathers every trick that side wins and stacks them face down in front of them, squared up and countable, rather than scattering them. Once a trick has been turned over and covered by the next one it is closed, and you are not allowed to look back through earlier tricks. Remembering what has gone is the whole skill of the game. Tables vary on whether the trick just completed may be re-examined before the next card is led; the strict rule is that only the trick currently in progress is public.

There is nothing to say during a hand. Whist is deliberately silent: no signalling, no remarks about your holding, no reaction to a partner's card. The turned trump and the fall of the cards are the only information anyone is entitled to, and drawing inferences from them is what you are there to do.

Playing off-suit when you could have followed suit is a revoke. Once it has been established, the standard remedy is that three tricks, or three points, are transferred from the offending side to their opponents at the end of the hand, and the offending side may not win the game on that deal. A revoke spotted and corrected before the trick is turned is usually just fixed on the spot, with the withdrawn card left face up as information for the opponents.

When the thirteenth trick is done, each side counts the tricks it won and the deal is scored. The deal then passes one seat to the left and the next hand is dealt.

Goal & scoring

Six tricks is the book and is worth nothing at all. Only tricks beyond six count, at 1 point each, which means a single hand is worth at most 7 points and both sides can never score in the same deal.

A game is 5 points in the standard British short whist. American play traditionally used 7, and older long whist ran to 9, which is where the game's reputation for endless sessions comes from. Whichever target you use, a rubber is the best of three games: the first side to win two games takes the rubber and adds 2 bonus points. If one side wins the first two games the third is not played. The rubber is settled by the difference between the two sides' point totals once the bonus is added.

Honours are the ace, king, queen and jack of the trump suit, and they score for having been dealt, not for having been won in tricks. A partnership dealt all four honours between its two hands scores 4 extra points at the end of the hand; three of the four scores 2. Two limits apply. Trick points are always counted before honours, so a side that reaches the target on tricks wins immediately. And a side already standing at 4 points towards a 5-point game may not score honours at all, on the principle that you should not be carried over the line by cards you merely held.

Many modern groups drop honours entirely and score tricks only, which makes the game a cleaner test of play. Decide which you are using before the first deal.

Variants

Bid Whist — The American partnership game built on whist, played hard and fast. Both jokers join the pack as a big and a little joker, each player is dealt 12 cards and six go face down as the kitty. Bidding runs from 3 to 7, meaning tricks above the book of six, and the winning bidder names trump or no-trump plus a direction: uptown, with the ranks in their usual order, or downtown, with them inverted so that after the ace the 2 is the strongest card and the king the weakest. The high bidder takes the kitty into hand and buries six cards face down, which count as a trick for that side. The bidding side scores tricks above six when it makes the contract and loses the value of its bid when it is set. Game is normally 7 points, and a side driven to minus 7 loses.

Knock-Out Whist — A short elimination game for three to seven players and a staple of British family card play. The first hand is seven cards each, with the top card of the undealt remainder turned to set trump. Tricks are played as in ordinary whist, but nothing is scored: any player who wins no tricks at all is knocked out. The player who took the most tricks deals the next hand and simply names trump after looking at their cards, with ties settled by a cut. Hands shrink by one card every round, seven down to one, and the last player standing wins. A common kindness is the dog's life, which lets the very first player eliminated stay in with a single card each round, played to whichever trick they choose.

German Whist — The two-player version, and the best-known one. Deal 13 cards each and put the remaining 26 face down as a stock with the top card turned up; its suit is trump for the entire hand. The first thirteen tricks are played for the stock rather than for score: the winner of each trick takes the exposed card, the loser takes the next card unseen, and a fresh card is turned. When the stock is exhausted both players hold 13 known-quality cards and play them out, and only these last thirteen tricks count, at 1 point for each trick above six. The first half is a card-drafting duel, the second half is pure technique.

Solo Whist — Four players, but each hand becomes an auction of individual contracts rather than a partnership affair. Cards are dealt in batches of three, then a final four, with the last card turned for trump. The bids in ascending order are: a proposal to take eight tricks with whoever accepts it, solo for five tricks alone in the turned trump, misere for losing every trick with no trump, abundance for nine tricks alone with a trump suit of your own choosing, open misere with your hand face up on the table, and a declared abundance for all thirteen. Results are settled in chips or units paid between the players hand by hand instead of accumulating on a score sheet.

Rules verified against: Pagat, Bicycle Cards, Britannica, Official Game Rules, Trickster Cards, Gamerules.com, Card Game Rules. Original text; not reproduced from those sources.

RUMMY FAMILY

500 Rummy

Also known as	Rummy 500, 500 Rum, Pinochle Rummy
Players	2-8 players (best with 4)
Deck	1 standard deck (52 cards) for 2 to 4 players; 2 decks shuffled together (104 cards) for 5 or more
Time	30-60 minutes
Difficulty	Medium
Category	Rummy family

Setup

Two to eight can play. Up to four players use a single 52-card pack; from five players up, shuffle two packs together and treat identical cards as interchangeable. Draw for the first deal, high card deals, and pass the deal to the left after each hand.

Deal 7 cards to each player, one at a time, clockwise from the dealer's left. In the two-player game deal 13 each instead. Place the remainder face down as the stock and turn its top card face up to begin the discard pile.

The discard pile is the heart of this game, so lay it out properly. Every discard goes on the pile offset from the one below it, fanned so that every card in the pile stays readable to everyone for the whole hand. Never square it up.

Aces work high or low but never both in the same run: A-2-3 and Q-K-A are legal, K-A-2 is not. Point values are what you will be adding up all game. An ace is worth 15, except when it is melded low in a sequence with the 2, where it counts 1. Kings, queens and jacks are 10 each. Every other card is worth its number. The player to the dealer's left starts.

Play

Melds are the usual two shapes: a set of three or four cards of the same rank, or a run of three or more cards of one suit in sequence. Unlike most rummies, melds are laid face up in front of you and stay yours, because at the end of the hand you are paid for the cards sitting on the table in front of you.

A turn is draw, then meld or lay off, then discard.

Drawing is where 500 Rummy differs from everything else in the family. You may take the top card of the stock, or you may reach into the discard pile and take any card in it, however deep. If you take a buried card, you must also take every card lying above it, and all of those go into your hand. The price of digging is an obligation: the card you reached for has to go straight onto the table this turn, either as part of a fresh meld you lay down or laid off onto a meld already showing. If you cannot place it immediately, you are not allowed to take it. Everything you scooped up on top of it is yours to keep and use later, or to be caught with.

That obligation is what makes the pile dangerous. A convenient discard early on can sit there for ten turns and then be dragged out from under a stack of eight cards by an opponent who wanted the one card underneath, and they get all eight.

Taking only the top card of the discard pile is the ordinary exception: you may take it without having to use it, exactly as in basic Rummy. Some groups apply the melding obligation to the top card as well, so settle it before you deal.

After drawing you may lay down as many melds as you like, and you may lay off cards onto any meld on the table, including melds belonging to your opponents. A card laid off is placed physically with the meld it extends, but it counts for you when scores are worked out, so feeding an opponent's run is a perfectly good way to bank points. Nothing has to be melded; a card kept in hand is only a liability at the end of the hand.

Finish by discarding one card face up, adding it to the fan.

The hand ends the moment one player has no cards left, whether their last card went down in a meld, was laid off, or was discarded. Everyone else is caught with whatever is still in hand.

A hand can also end without anyone going out. If the stock is empty and the player whose turn it is either cannot use the discard pile or chooses not to, the hand stops there and is scored as it stands. The discard pile is not turned over to make a new stock.

Goal & scoring

Score each hand separately, then keep a running total. The first player to reach 500 points wins. If two or more cross 500 in the same hand, the highest total takes it.

At the end of a hand, each player adds up the value of every card they have on the table, counting melds they laid down and cards they laid off onto anybody's meld, then subtracts the value of every card still in their hand. Aces are 15, or 1 when melded low against a 2; face cards are 10; everything else is its number.

The result can easily be negative, and negative scores really are subtracted from your running total, so a player caught with two aces and a couple of kings while holding nothing on the table goes backwards. That is the game's main pressure: melding early banks points but tells everyone what you are collecting, while sitting on cards to build a bigger play risks handing back more than you make.

Going out is worth having but carries no bonus in the standard game. Its value is that it ends the hand while everyone else is still holding cards.

Variants

Going-out bonus — Award the player who sheds their last card a flat bonus, most commonly 25 points, on top of their melds. Some tables also pay a bonus for going out in a single turn without having melded anything earlier in the hand. Either rule pushes play toward finishing hands quickly rather than grinding out meld points, which shortens the game considerably.

Deal and target adjustments — Plenty of groups deal 7 cards in the two-player game rather than 13, which makes for shorter, tighter hands with a deeper stock. Targets move too: 200 or 300 for a quick session, 1000 for a long one. Some also stop the game after a fixed number of deals and simply take the highest score.

Wild jokers — Add one or two jokers as wild cards that can stand for any card in a meld. Fix their value before you start, usually 15 or 20 points, counting for you on the table and against you in hand. A common companion rule lets a player who holds the natural card a joker is standing in for swap it into the meld and take the joker.

Michigan Rum — Played with 52 cards plus four jokers. The jokers are not wild here: they form a rank of their own and can only be melded as a group of three or four jokers together, never inside a run and never as a substitute. Each one is worth 20 points, which makes a set of jokers a large swing and being caught holding one expensive.

Persian Rummy — A four-player partnership relative using 52 cards and four jokers, with partners sitting opposite and their scores combined. Aces rank high only, so A-2-3 is not a run. Jokers count 20 apiece and are treated as their own rank rather than as wild cards. The game runs to 500 like the parent game, but partnership play changes the calculation on laying off, since helping your partner's meld helps your own side.

Rules verified against: Pagat, Bicycle Cards, Wikipedia, Denexa Games, Official Game Rules, Cool Old Games, Game Rules. Original text; not reproduced from those sources.

Canasta

Also known as	Classic Canasta, Argentine Canasta
Players	2-4 players (best with 4)
Deck	2 standard decks plus 4 jokers (108 cards)
Time	60-120 minutes
Difficulty	Complex
Category	Rummy family

Setup

Four players in two fixed partnerships, partners sitting opposite each other. Shuffle two full 52-card decks together with four jokers: 108 cards. Cut for seats and first deal if you want a formal start, high card choosing; after that the deal passes clockwise each hand.

Deal 11 cards to each player, one at a time. Set the remaining cards face down in the middle as the stock and turn its top card face up beside it to begin the discard pile. If that upcard is a joker, a two, or a red three, turn another card on top of it and keep going until an ordinary card is showing. When that happens the pile starts the hand frozen; leave the wild card or red three sticking out crossways so everyone can see it stays frozen.

Before the first turn, every player puts any red threes from their dealt hand face up on the table in front of them and draws one replacement card from the stock for each, repeating if a replacement is itself a red three. The player to the dealer's left plays first.

Melds belong to the partnership, not the player, so keep them all in one group in front of one partner where both of you can reach them. Score is kept per partnership across as many deals as the game takes.

Play

Play goes clockwise, and a turn has three parts: take cards, meld if you want to, then discard one card face up on the pile. Melding is optional; taking and discarding are not.

Taking cards. Either draw the top card of the stock, or take the whole discard pile when you are entitled to. If you ever draw a red three, lay it down face up at once and draw another card to replace it.

Melds. A meld is three or more cards of the same rank, four through ace, and suits are irrelevant. Jokers and twos are wild and may be included, but a meld must always hold at least two natural cards and may never hold more than three wild cards. There are no sequences in Canasta. Your side may have only one meld of any given rank, so instead of starting a second you add to the one already on the table; either partner may add to any of the side's melds at any time. Cards on the table stay there and cannot be taken back into hand.

Threes. Red threes are never melded or held in hand; they sit face up in front of you doing nothing but scoring. Black threes may be melded only on the turn you go out, and only as a natural set of three or four with no wild card among them.

The first meld. Neither partner may put anything down until the side lays out melds whose card points reach a minimum set by their score at the start of the deal: 15 points if the score is below zero, 50 from 0 to 1,495, 90 from 1,500 to 2,995, and 120 at 3,000 or above. The whole requirement must be satisfied in one turn, and only the face value of the cards counts toward it. Red threes, canasta bonuses, and the going-out bonus do not help. If you make the initial meld

while taking the discard pile, the top card counts but the buried cards do not.

Taking the discard pile. You must use the top card immediately in a meld, and you always take the entire pile, never part of it. If the pile is not frozen against you, you may take it either by matching the top card with two natural cards of that rank from your hand, or by adding the top card to one of your side's existing melds, though not to one that is already a completed canasta of seven. If the pile is frozen against you, only the first way works: two natural cards of the same rank from your hand, melded together with the top discard. The pile is frozen for everyone once a wild card or red three lies buried in it, it is frozen against any side that has not yet made its initial meld, and it starts frozen if the first upcard was a wild card or red three. A frozen pile stays frozen until somebody takes it.

Black threes. Discarding a black three stops the next player from taking the pile no matter what they hold, but that block lasts one turn only and does not freeze the pile.

Canastas. A meld of seven or more cards is a canasta. Square it up and mark it with a red card on top if it is natural (no wilds) or a black card if it is mixed. You may keep adding cards afterwards, but laying a wild card on a natural canasta turns it into a mixed one.

Going out. You go out when you play the last card from your hand, whether as a discard, a new meld, or an addition to an existing one; finishing with a meld and no discard is allowed. Your side must have completed at least one canasta first. Before you touch anything on your turn you may ask your partner "may I go out?" and you are bound by the yes or no you get. Once you have melded or reached for the pile, you have given up the right to ask.

If your side has not melded yet and you draw from the stock into a hand you can lay down complete, canasta included, you may go out concealed on the spot without meeting the minimum count. Take the pile instead of drawing and that concession disappears: you must make the minimum, and the concealed bonus is not yours to claim.

When the stock runs out. If the last stock card is a red three, the player shows it and the hand ends immediately with no discard. Otherwise play continues with no stock: each player in turn must take the discard pile if its top card matches one of their side's melds and the pile is not frozen against them. The moment a player cannot do that, the hand stops there with nobody going out.

Goal & scoring

The partnership target is 5,000 points, played out over as many deals as it takes. Each deal is scored for the side as a whole.

Card values: jokers 50; twos and aces 20; kings, queens, jacks, tens, nines, and eights 10; sevens, sixes, fives, fours, and black threes 5. Add up everything your side has melded and subtract the value of every card still in either partner's hand.

Bonuses: 500 for each natural canasta, 300 for each mixed canasta, and 100 for going out. Going out concealed is worth 200 instead, which means laying down your whole hand in a single turn including a canasta, having never melded or added to your partner's melds earlier in the deal.

Red threes count 100 each for the side that laid them down, but only if that side made its initial meld; a side that never melded has the same 100 per red three deducted. Holding all four doubles it to 800 for or 800 against.

A deal can easily come out negative. Add each deal to the running total, since that total sets the next deal's minimum meld. The game ends when a side reaches 5,000 or more once a deal has been fully scored; if both sides cross 5,000 in the same deal, the higher total wins.

Variants

Two- and three-player Canasta — With two players, each is dealt 15 cards, a stock draw takes two cards rather than one (you still discard only one), everyone plays alone, and you need two canastas to go out. With three, deal 13 cards each and again play as individuals with the standard one-canasta requirement. Everything else follows the four-hand game.

Samba — Three decks and six jokers, 162 cards, for up to six players, dealt 15 each. Alongside ordinary rank melds you may build suited sequences; a run of seven cards in one suit is a samba, counts as a canasta for going out, and scores 1,500. Stock draws take two cards, going out needs two canastas, and the game runs to 10,000 with the initial meld minimum climbing to 150 once a side passes 7,000.

Hand and Foot — The most popular North American descendant, usually four to six decks with jokers. Each player gets two packets, commonly 11 cards as the hand and 13 as the foot; you play the hand first and only pick up the foot after emptying it. Melds are built toward books of seven, clean (no wilds) or dirty (with wilds), and going out typically demands a set quota of each, so a partnership cannot finish early on a thin table.

Modern American Canasta — The version most tournament and club play now uses. Initial melds must come entirely from the hand and must include a set of three or more natural cards, wild cards may be collected into a canasta of their own for a very large bonus (and a heavy penalty if left unfinished), and a partnership needs two canastas rather than one to go out. Melded ranks that can no longer be completed are treated as dead, which changes discard strategy considerably.

Rules verified against: Pagat, Bicycle Cards, Wikipedia, Britannica, Hoyle's Rules of Games, Canasta League of America, GameRules.com. Original text; not reproduced from those sources.

Gin Rummy

Also known as	Gin
Players	2 players
Deck	1 standard deck (52 cards), jokers removed
Time	20-45 minutes
Difficulty	Easy
Category	Rummy family

Setup

Gin Rummy is a two-handed game using a full 52-card pack with the jokers taken out. Pick the first dealer by drawing from the shuffled pack: low card deals. After that the loser of each hand deals the next one, though plenty of players pass the deal to the winner instead, so agree which before you start.

The dealer shuffles, the opponent cuts, and ten cards go to each player one at a time, non-dealer first. Put the rest of the pack face down in the middle as the stock and turn its top card face up next to it. That upcard is the whole discard pile for now, and it leaves 31 cards in the stock.

Ranks run from ace low up to king, and they do not wrap. A-2-3 is a legal sequence; Q-K-A is not. For counting, an ace is 1 point, a numbered card is worth its number, and each jack, queen and king is 10. Keep your hand hidden. Nothing goes on the table until somebody ends the hand.

Play

There are two kinds of meld. A set is three or four cards of the same rank. A run is three or more cards of one suit in sequence. Each card can only work in one meld at a time, so holding 7♣ 7♠ 7♥ 8♥ 9♥ you may count the set of sevens or the heart run, not both. Everything outside your melds is deadwood, and its point total is what the whole game turns on.

The first turn has its own procedure. The non-dealer may take the upcard or refuse it. If they refuse, the dealer gets the same offer. If both refuse, the non-dealer opens by drawing the top card of the stock. Whoever takes a card then discards, and the players alternate normally from there.

An ordinary turn is two actions with nothing in between. Draw exactly one card, either the face-down top of the stock or the face-up top of the discard pile, then discard exactly one card face up onto the pile. You are back to ten cards at the end of every turn. You may not take the top discard and throw the same card straight back on that turn. Melds are never laid on the table during play; they stay in your hand until the hand ends.

You end the hand by knocking. You may knock on any turn, including your first, as long as your deadwood after discarding comes to 10 points or less. To do it, lay your final discard face down instead of face up, then spread your hand with the melds grouped separately from the deadwood and state your count. Knocking is optional. With a low count you are allowed to keep playing and hunt for a bigger score, at the risk of being knocked on first.

Zero deadwood is gin. Declare it the same way, spreading a hand in which every card is melded once the discard is gone.

Your opponent now spreads too. They arrange their own melds and then lay off: any loose card of theirs that fits one of your melds can be pushed onto it, adding a fourth card to a set or

extending either end of a run. Every card laid off comes out of their deadwood. Two restrictions matter. Nothing can be laid off against a gin hand, and nothing can ever be laid off onto the other player's deadwood.

Once the laying off is finished the two deadwood counts are compared, which decides who scores the hand.

The stock can run out. If a player draws the card that leaves only two cards in the stock and then discards without knocking, the hand is dead: neither player scores, and the same dealer deals again. Those last two stock cards are never drawn.

Goal & scoring

Hands are only steps toward the match target, which is 100 points.

A knock that survives scores the knocker the difference between the two deadwood counts. Knock with 6 against an opponent left holding 21 and you take 15. If the opponent's count after laying off is lower than yours, or exactly equal to it, they have undercut you: they score the difference plus a 25-point undercut bonus, and an equal count still counts as an undercut, worth the flat 25. Gin scores 25 plus every point of deadwood in the opponent's hand, and it can be neither laid off against nor undercut.

Keep running totals. The game ends as soon as either player's total reaches 100 at the end of a hand. Then add the bonuses: each player scores 25 for every individual hand they won, called a box or line bonus, and whoever reached 100 first adds a 100-point game bonus. If the loser never won a single hand, the winner doubles their entire total, game bonus included, which is known as a shutout, blitz or schneider. The higher total after bonuses wins the match, and the gap between the totals is the margin that gets settled.

Variants

Oklahoma Gin — The first upcard fixes the knock limit for the whole deal instead of the standard 10. If it is a 6, nobody may knock with more than 6 points of deadwood; face cards set the limit at 10, so an ordinary deal. Most tables add that an ace as the upcard means only gin ends the hand, and many use a spades-double rule where a spade upcard doubles everything scored that deal. This is the most widely played competitive form of the game.

Hollywood Gin — A scoring frame rather than a rules change: three games are tracked at once in three columns. The first hand a player wins is entered in their first column only, their second win goes into the first and second columns, and every win after that goes into all three. Each column is a separate race to 100 with its own bonuses, so a match runs longer and an early lead is worth much more.

Straight Gin — Knocking is abolished. The only way to end a hand is to go gin with all ten cards melded, which means no undercuts, no laying off and no partial scores. Hands run much longer and the whole discard-reading side of the game gets sharper, because you cannot bail out of a bad hand with a cheap knock.

Big Gin — An extra bonus recognised at many tables. If the card you draw gives you eleven melded cards with no discard needed, you declare big gin and score 31 plus your opponent's deadwood instead of the usual 25. Some groups score it at 25 like ordinary gin, so settle the number in advance.

Three- and four-handed gin — For three, the usual arrangement is that one player sits out each deal and the two active players use the standard rules, with the winner staying in and the

loser swapping out. For four, play as two partnerships: each player faces one opponent in a separate two-handed hand, then the partners' results for that round are combined and only the net difference is entered on the score sheet.

Rules verified against: Pagat, Bicycle Cards, Wikipedia, Britannica, Denexa Games, Official Game Rules, Cool Old Games. Original text; not reproduced from those sources.

Rummy

Also known as	Rum, Straight Rummy, Basic Rummy
Players	2-6 players (best with 4)
Deck	1 standard deck (52 cards)
Time	20-45 minutes
Difficulty	Easy
Category	Rummy family

Setup

Use one 52-card pack with the jokers removed. Any fair method picks the first dealer; drawing cards and giving the deal to the highest is common, and the deal then passes to the left after each hand.

How many cards you get depends on the size of the table. With two players, deal 10 each. With three or four, deal 7 each. With five or six, deal 6 each. Deal one card at a time, face down, clockwise, starting with the player on the dealer's left.

Put the rest of the pack face down in the middle as the stock, then turn its top card face up beside it to start the discard pile. Only the top card of that pile is ever available, so keep it squared up rather than spread.

Aces are low. A-2-3 is a run and Q-K-A is not, unless you agree otherwise before the first deal. For scoring, an ace is 1 point, each numbered card is worth its number, and a jack, queen or king is 10. The player to the dealer's left takes the first turn.

Play

You are trying to get rid of every card in your hand by arranging them into melds. A set is three or four cards of the same rank, such as three nines. A run is three or more cards of one suit in sequence, such as 5♠ 6♠ 7♠. A card can only belong to one meld at a time.

A turn has three parts and always happens in this order.

First, draw. Take either the top card of the stock, sight unseen, or the top card of the discard pile, which everyone can see. You draw exactly one card, and you may not dig deeper into the discard pile.

Second, meld if you want to. Lay any complete set or run from your hand face up in front of you. You may also lay off: add a card to any meld already on the table, yours or an opponent's, by putting a fourth card on a set or extending either end of a run. Laying off is how single cards get used up late in a hand, and the card belongs to the meld it joins, not to the player who originally laid it. Melding is always optional, even when you can. Holding a completed meld back keeps your options open but risks getting caught with it.

Third, discard. Put one card face up on the discard pile. That ends your turn and passes play to the left. The one thing you cannot do is take the top discard and immediately throw the same card back.

Two points worth agreeing before you deal, because tables differ. Some groups let you lay down as many melds as you like on a turn while others allow only one per turn, and some require you to have melded something of your own before you are allowed to lay off on other players. The looser version of both is the more common modern game.

The hand ends when somebody goes out, which means playing their last card. You can go out by melding, by laying off, or by discarding your final card, and any mix of those in one turn. In the basic game you do not need to keep a card back for a final discard, though a good number of households insist on it.

If nobody has gone out by the time the stock is empty, turn the discard pile over to make a fresh stock, leaving its top card face up as the new discard, and carry on. Some players shuffle it first. If the deck cycles again with no progress, most groups simply end the hand and score it where it stands.

Going out in a single turn, with no previous melds or lay-offs at all, is going rummy and pays double. To do it you must put your entire hand down on one turn, having laid nothing on the table earlier in the deal.

Goal & scoring

The object of each hand is to be first to shed every card. The object of the game is to reach an agreed target, most often 100 or 500, over as many hands as it takes; a fixed number of deals works just as well as long as everyone agrees before the first shuffle.

When a player goes out, everyone else counts the cards still in their hand. Melds already on the table do not count for or against anybody, and neither do cards you laid off. Aces are 1, numbered cards are face value, and jacks, queens and kings are 10 each. The winner of the hand scores the sum of everything all the other players are left holding.

Going rummy doubles the whole amount collected for that hand.

The common alternative is penalty scoring: instead of the winner collecting, each losing player writes down the value of their own leftover cards as a plus score, the winner writes zero, and the game runs until someone crosses an agreed limit, at which point the lowest total wins.

Variants

Block Rummy — The discard pile is never recycled. When the stock runs out and the next player does not want the top discard, the hand stops there and nobody goes out. Everyone counts the cards in their hand as penalty points, including the player who would otherwise have won. It makes hoarding a big hand far more dangerous and speeds the game up noticeably.

Boathouse Rum — A sharper two-player version. If you take the top discard you must then draw a second card, either the next discard or the top of the stock, but you still discard only one, so your hand grows. An ace may be used high or low, but not both ends at once, and it costs 11 points if you are caught holding it. You may not meld or lay off at all until the turn on which you go out, so every hand is played entirely from concealment.

Knock Rummy — Also called Poker Rum. Nothing is laid on the table during play. Instead, any player may end the hand on their turn by discarding face down and knocking, then spreading their hand. Everyone reveals, counts their unmelded cards, and the lowest count wins the difference from each of the others. Knocking with a count that turns out not to be lowest is punished with a penalty, so the bluffing element sits in when you dare to stop the hand.

Wild cards — Add one or two jokers, or nominate a rank such as deuces, as wild cards that can stand in for anything in a meld. A common accompanying rule lets a later player swap the natural card for a wild one sitting in a meld on the table and take the wild card into hand. Wilds usually carry a heavy penalty value, often 15 or 20 points, if you are caught holding one at the end of a hand.

Rules verified against: Pagat, Bicycle Cards, Wikipedia, Britannica, Official Game Rules, Denexa Games. Original text; not reproduced from those sources.

SHEDDING

Crazy Eights

Also known as	Eights, Crazy 8s, Swedish Rummy, Rockaway, Last One, Craits
Players	2-7 players (best with 4)
Deck	1 standard deck (52 cards) for two to five players; 2 decks shuffled together (104 cards) for six or seven
Time	15-30 minutes
Difficulty	Simple
Category	Shedding

Setup

Take the jokers out. One 52-card pack handles up to five players; with six or seven, shuffle two packs together and treat them as a single deck of 104. Duplicate cards cause no trouble, since suits and ranks only ever have to be matched, never compared.

Rank order is irrelevant while you are playing. Nothing beats anything else, and an ace is neither high nor low. Rank matters only at the end of the hand, when you count up what is left in the losers' hands.

Pick a first dealer any way you like; cutting for the high card is the usual method. The deal then moves one seat to the left after each hand. The dealer shuffles and deals one card at a time, clockwise, starting with the player on their left. In a two-player game each side gets seven cards. With three or more, everyone gets five.

Put the undealt cards face down in the middle as the stock, then turn the top one face up next to it. That card is the starter and it forms the beginning of the discard pile. If the starter happens to be an eight, slide it back into the middle of the stock and turn a fresh card, because nobody wants the hand to open on a wild card. Repeat until you get an ordinary starter.

The player to the dealer's left goes first, and play runs clockwise.

Play

On your turn you add exactly one card to the top of the discard pile. The card you play must agree with the card currently showing in either its suit or its rank. A ten of hearts, for example, can be covered by any other heart or by any other ten. That is the whole of the matching rule.

Eights are the exception, and they are wild. You may play an eight on top of anything at all, whatever the suit or rank showing, and you may do it on any turn. When you put an eight down you immediately name a suit out loud. The next player has to follow that named suit as though the eight were a card of it, and the named suit stays in force until somebody legally changes it. You are free to name the suit the eight itself belongs to, and you are free to name a suit you hold nothing in. You cannot name "eights" or a rank; only a suit. The only card that can be laid on an eight without regard to the suit called is another eight, which resets the naming.

If you have no legal play, you draw. The common rule is that you keep drawing one card at a time from the stock until you turn up something you can play, and you then play it and your turn ends. Groups vary here: some let you draw only a single card and pass whether or not it helps, and some cap the draw at three. Whichever you use, agree on it before the first deal, because it changes the game noticeably. A player who has a legal play in most versions must make it rather than draw by choice; if your group allows drawing when you could have played, say so up

front.

When the stock runs out, take the discard pile, leave its top card in place, shuffle the rest and set them down as a new stock. If the discard pile has nothing to spare either, then the stock is simply gone. From that point a player with no legal play passes their turn instead of drawing. If the turn goes all the way around with every player passing, the hand is blocked and ends immediately with nobody going out.

Otherwise the hand ends the moment a player lays down their last card. The standard rule lets you go out on an eight, naming a suit that nobody will ever have to follow; plenty of groups ban this, so settle it in advance. Some tables also require a player down to one card to announce it before their next turn, with a penalty draw for forgetting, exactly the way the commercial versions of the game do.

Goal & scoring

Your aim in each hand is to be the first to run out of cards. Over a session, the aim is to be first to an agreed point target.

When someone goes out, every other player counts what is still in their hand: 50 for each eight, 10 for each king, queen, jack or ten, 1 for each ace, and face value for everything from two through nine. The player who went out scores the combined total of all the opposing hands. A target of 100 makes for a short game; 500 is the other common choice, and some groups simply agree on a fixed number of deals and add up as they go.

If the hand blocks because the stock is exhausted and nobody can play, the player with the smallest hand total is credited with the difference between their own total and each opponent's, which is usually a much thinner score than going out cleanly.

A popular alternative flips the bookkeeping. Instead of the winner banking the opponents' cards, each player records the value of the cards left in their own hand as penalty points. Play stops as soon as anyone hits 100, and the lowest score at that moment wins. The card values are identical either way; only who receives the points changes.

Variants

Special-card eights — The house-rule package that most tables end up adopting, and the one that commercial versions were built from. A two forces the next player to draw two cards and lose their turn, unless they can lay a two of their own, in which case the penalty stacks and passes along. A queen skips the next player. An ace reverses the direction of play, so it works as a skip in a two-handed game. A jack is sometimes used as a second skip. The eight stays wild through all of this. Once you have these on the table you are effectively playing Uno with a standard pack, which is roughly how Uno came about: it was designed in 1971 by an Ohio barber named Merle Robbins after arguments about exactly these kinds of Crazy Eights house rules.

Mau-Mau — The German game that Crazy Eights descends from, still played across central Europe and sold under other names in Switzerland and the Netherlands. It is usually played with a 32-card pack. The jack, not the eight, is the wild card that lets you name a suit. A seven makes the next player draw two, and those penalties stack if they hold a seven of their own. An eight skips a turn. You must call out "Mau" as you play your second-to-last card and "Mau-Mau" as you play the last, and forgetting costs you a penalty draw.

Switch — The British form, and the one most often meant when someone talks about playing Switch or Black Jack. The suit-changing wild card is the ace rather than the eight. Twos make the next player pick up two, and stack if that player also holds a two. Eights or jacks skip a turn depending on the group, and the black jacks are often a heavy pick-up penalty that only a red jack can cancel. A player down to their last card must announce it before their turn ends.

Crazy Eights Countdown — Each player is given a personal countdown number that starts at eight. The card of that rank is that player's own wild card, so at the beginning everyone's wild card is the eight. Playing your wild card lets you name a suit and knocks your countdown down by one, so your wild card becomes the seven, then the six, and so on. The first player to work all the way down to zero wins the whole game outright, no scoring required. Special powers are usually layered on top: jacks skip the next player, twos force a draw of two, and the queen of spades makes the next player draw five.

Draw-one Eights — The most common single point of disagreement about this game, played as a deliberate rule rather than a mistake. A player who cannot follow suit or rank draws exactly one card from the stock. If it plays, they may play it; if it does not, their turn is over and the next player goes. Hands stay much smaller than in the draw-until-you-can version, deals run quicker, and blocked hands become far more frequent, so the tie-break scoring for a blocked hand actually gets used.

Rules verified against: Pagat, Bicycle Cards, Wikipedia, Britannica, Dice Game Depot, Official Game Rules, Game Rules, Ducksters, PlayingCardDecks. Original text; not reproduced from those sources.

Egyptian Ratscrew

Also known as	Egyptian Rat Screw, ERS, Egyptian War, Egyptian Rat Slap, Slaps
Players	2-8 players (best with 4)
Deck	1 standard deck (52 cards); some groups leave the jokers in so the deal comes out even, or add a second deck above six players
Time	15-45 minutes
Difficulty	Easy
Category	Shedding

Setup

You need a flat surface everyone can reach and hit. A table is better than a floor, and a hard surface is better than a bed, because the pile has to stay square enough to see the top card.

Pick a dealer any way you like. Shuffle and deal the whole pack out one card at a time, face down, going clockwise, until the cards run out. Hands will be uneven unless the player count divides into 52, and a one- or two-card difference does not matter. Some groups leave the two jokers in purely so the deal comes out level at three, six or thirteen players.

Nobody looks at their cards, ever, including their own. Square your cards into a neat face-down stack in front of you and keep it squared: you play off the top and add winnings to the bottom, so a sloppy stack slows you down and lets people see cards early.

Before the first card is turned, agree on two things out loud. First, which slap patterns are live. Doubles and sandwiches are near-universal; top-bottom, marriages, tens and runs are optional and every group plays a different set. Second, what a false slap costs, normally one card burned to the bottom of the pile, sometimes two. Arguments about these mid-game are what the game is famous for.

The player to the dealer's left turns the first card. Play runs clockwise.

Play

On your turn, take the top card off your own stack and flip it face up onto the pile in the middle. Grab it by the far edge and turn it away from you, so that everyone sees it at the same moment. Turning a card toward yourself gives you a fraction of a second's head start on slapping and is treated as cheating.

If the card is a 2 through 10 and does not complete a slap pattern, nothing happens and the turn simply passes to the next player.

FACE CARD CHALLENGES

Jacks, queens, kings and aces stop the normal rotation. When you turn one, the next player owes you a face card, and the rank you played sets how many attempts they get:

- jack: 1 card
- queen: 2 cards
- king: 3 cards
- ace: 4 cards

That player flips cards from their own stack onto the pile, one at a time, up to that limit. Two outcomes are possible.

If one of the cards they flip is itself a face card or an ace, they stop immediately, even if they had attempts left. The challenge now passes to the player after them, with the count reset by whatever rank was just turned. Challenges can chain around the table several times and the pile gets fat.

If they use up all their attempts without turning a face card or ace, the challenge is over. The player who turned the most recent face card takes the entire pile, puts it face down under their own stack, and turns the first card of a brand-new pile.

Note that the cards flipped during a challenge are ordinary cards on the pile. They can and do complete slap patterns, which is where most of the chaos comes from.

SLAPPING

Slapping outranks everything, including a challenge in progress. The instant the top of the pile completes a live pattern, anyone at the table may slap it, including the player who just turned the card and including players who are not part of the current challenge. The first hand onto the pile takes the whole thing, adds it face down to the bottom of their stack, and turns the first card of the next pile. Play then continues clockwise from them.

The standard patterns:

- Double: the top two cards are the same rank, for example 7 then 7.
- Sandwich: two cards of the same rank with exactly one card between them, for example 9, 4, 9.
- Top-bottom: the card just turned matches the rank of the very bottom card of the pile.

Common optional additions, all of which must be agreed in advance: marriage, a king and queen next to each other in either order; tens, two consecutive cards whose values add to exactly ten, with face cards not counting; and runs, three or four cards in consecutive rank order, up or down.

If several hands land at once, the bottom hand wins, meaning whoever is actually touching the cards rather than the back of someone else's hand.

BURNING

Slap when there is no pattern and you burn a card. Take the top card of your own stack, without looking at it, and slide it face down underneath the pile. You get nothing for it; it becomes part of whatever pile the next winner collects. Some groups burn two cards, and some make a player who false-slaps repeatedly sit out slapping for the rest of the game.

RUNNING OUT OF CARDS

Playing your last card does not eliminate you. You stay at the table with an empty space in front of you and you may still slap. Win a slap and the entire pile comes to you, and you are back in with a large stack. This is why the game can run so long: a player who is down to nothing can be the leader thirty seconds later.

You are out when someone else claims the pile while you are cardless, because your chance to slap back in has gone. A player with no cards who owes a face card obviously cannot produce one, so the challenge ends and the challenger takes the pile. A cardless player who false-slaps has nothing to burn; the usual ruling is that they are out on the spot.

Groups vary on how generous to be here. Some let eliminated players, and even people who were not playing, keep slapping in indefinitely.

Goal & scoring

There is no scoring. You win by holding all 52 cards, which in practice means everyone else has been knocked out and you are the only player left with a stack.

Getting all the way there can take a while, because a cardless player who slaps well comes straight back into the game, and a full-table game can swing several times before anyone is genuinely eliminated. It is entirely normal for one player to hold forty cards and lose ten minutes later.

Because of that, plenty of groups set a stopping point in advance: play for a fixed twenty or thirty minutes and give the win to whoever has the biggest stack, or stop as soon as the table is down to two players and call the larger stack the winner. Decide before you start rather than when someone is winning.

The skill is not really reflexes. It is watching the pile rather than your own hand, knowing the pattern list cold so you are not thinking about it, and resisting the twitch slap, because burned cards add up faster than anyone expects.

Variants

Long slap list — Beyond doubles and sandwiches, groups pile on extra patterns: marriage (king and queen adjacent, either order), tens (two consecutive cards adding to exactly ten), top-bottom, three or four cards in consecutive rank order, jokers as an instant slap, and a designated card such as the queen of spades that is always slappable. More patterns mean more piles change hands and fewer long face-card chains, but they also mean far more disputed slaps, so write the list down if it goes past four items.

Flat face-card counts — Instead of jack one, queen two, king three, ace four, every face card and ace gives the next player the same number of attempts, usually one. This is much easier to teach, and it is what most people default to when nobody at the table remembers the real counts. Challenges resolve faster and piles stay smaller, which makes the game shorter but takes away the tension of watching someone burn through four chances on an ace.

Harsher false-slap penalty — Instead of burning one card to the bottom of the pile, a false slapper burns two, or hands a card face down to every other player, which on a full table is brutal. A milder alternative used with children is a strike system: three false slaps and you lose the right to slap until the next game. All of these exist to stop the one player who slaps at everything and wins on volume.

Slapping in from outside — Eliminated players, and sometimes spectators who never dealt in at all, are allowed to keep slapping the pile. A successful slap brings them in with the whole pile as their stack. It keeps everyone involved instead of leaving knocked-out players watching, at the cost of a game that may never actually end. Groups that use it usually cap it, for example allowing a player one re-entry only.

Two packs for a big table — Above six players a single deck gives everyone six or seven cards and the game turns over almost instantly, so shuffle two packs together. Duplicate ranks make doubles and sandwiches noticeably more frequent, so the pile moves faster and face-card chains break sooner. Deal it out the same way and keep every other rule identical.

Rules verified against: Wikipedia, Bicycle Cards, Denexa Games, Official Game Rules, Game Rules, Gambiter, Group Games 101, Wikibooks, PlayingCardDecks. Original text; not reproduced from those sources.

Kings in the Corner

Also known as	Kings Corner, Kings Corners, King's Corner
Players	2-6 players (best with 4)
Deck	1 standard deck (52 cards), jokers removed
Time	15-30 minutes
Difficulty	Easy
Category	Shedding

Setup

Two to six can play. Three or four is the sweet spot; with six the stock empties quickly. Use a standard 52-card deck with the jokers taken out. Aces are low. The ranking runs K-Q-J-10-9-8-7-6-5-4-3-2-A, and nothing can ever be played on an ace because there is no rank below it.

Pick a dealer any way you like and pass the deal to the left after each round. Deal seven cards to each player, one at a time, clockwise. Put the remainder face down in the middle of the table as the stock.

Turn the top four cards of the stock face up and set them around the stock in a cross: one above, one below, one to the left, one to the right. Those four are the starting piles. The four diagonal positions between the arms of the cross stay empty. Those are the corners, and only a king may ever be placed in one.

If a king turns up among those first four cards, most groups slide it straight into a corner space and turn up a replacement for the arm of the cross, so the round starts in the usual shape. Leaving it where it landed is also playable, since a queen of the opposite colour goes on it either way. Agree which you are doing before the first turn.

Leave plenty of space around the cross. Piles grow outward as cards are added, and whole piles get picked up and relocated during play, so a cramped table gets confusing fast.

Play

The player to the dealer's left goes first and the turn passes clockwise.

Begin your turn by drawing one card from the stock into your hand. Then make as many plays as you can find, in whatever order you like, and stop when you choose. You are never obliged to play, and never obliged to stop while you still have legal moves. When you are finished, say so and pass.

Four kinds of play are legal.

1. Play a card from your hand onto a pile. It must be one rank lower than that pile's exposed card and the opposite colour. A red 9 goes on a black 10; a black 4 goes on a red 5. You may run several cards from your hand onto the same pile in one turn as long as each one continues the alternating sequence.
2. Start a corner pile with a king. A king from your hand may be placed in any empty corner space, and that pile then builds down in alternating colours exactly like the others. Kings go nowhere else. Since no rank outranks a king, a king can never be played onto an existing pile, so a corner is the only home it has.

3. Fill an empty arm of the cross. If one of the four original positions has been vacated, any card from your hand may be laid there to start a fresh pile. This applies only to the arms of the cross. An empty corner still requires a king.

4. Move an entire pile onto another pile. Look at the highest card of a pile, the one it started with. If that card is one rank lower and the opposite colour to the exposed card of some other pile, you may pick the whole pile up as a block and drop it on. A pile headed by a red 4 can go onto a pile whose exposed card is a black 5, taking everything below the 4 with it. You must move the pile intact; splitting it is not allowed. The point of the move is usually the space it leaves behind, which becomes somewhere to dump an awkward card.

There is no limit on how many of these you combine in one turn, and consolidating piles to open spaces is the main source of long turns.

The round ends the instant a player puts down the last card from their hand. If the stock runs out first, play carries on without drawing; anyone who cannot or will not move simply passes. Once the stock is gone and the turn has gone all the way around with nobody playing a card, the round is dead and everyone scores what they are still holding.

Goal & scoring

You are trying to empty your hand. The first player to do it wins the round and scores nothing.

Everyone else counts the cards still in hand: 1 penalty point per card, except kings, which cost 10 each. If the round ended in a stalemate with the stock exhausted and nobody out, every player scores their remaining cards the same way and no one takes the round.

Add the penalties across rounds and play to an agreed target. Twenty-five makes a short game and 100 a long one. When any player crosses the target, the game stops and the lowest total wins. A single deal scored on its own works perfectly well too.

The 10-point king penalty drives the tactics. A king can only be unloaded into a corner, so get one down as soon as a corner is free, and think twice about filling the last corner yourself while you still hold another king.

Variants

Chip pot — The version sold in a box, and the usual gambling form. Everyone antes one chip before the deal. The winner of the round takes the pot, and losers pay in one chip per card left in hand plus ten for each king. Some groups also charge a chip whenever you end a turn without making any play at all, which pushes people to keep the layout moving.

Draw at the end of the turn — Instead of drawing first, you play what you want and then draw a single card to close your turn. The card you pick up cannot be used until your next turn, so you go into everyone else's turns holding one more unknown card. It slows the game slightly and removes the free look you normally get before deciding what to play.

Compulsory play — You must make a play whenever a legal one exists, rather than holding cards back for a better moment. Many groups pair this with a king penalty: if you fail to place a king in an open corner and another player spots it, you pay a forfeit of three chips or three points. It cuts out defensive hoarding and shortens rounds noticeably.

Bigger hands for two — With only two players, deal ten cards each instead of seven. The seven-card deal leaves a very deep stock in a two-handed game, which drags the round out and makes it hard for either player to build momentum. Some groups go further and deal thirteen. The rest of the rules are untouched.

Rules verified against: Pagat, Bicycle Cards, Wikipedia, Geeky Hobbies, Dice Game Depot, Official Game Rules, Denexa Games. Original text; not reproduced from those sources.

Palace

Also known as	Shithead, Karma, Shed, Castle, Idiot, China Hand, Bastard
Players	2-6 players (best with 4)
Deck	1 standard deck (52 cards), jokers removed; 2 decks shuffled together for five or more players
Time	15-30 minutes
Difficulty	Easy
Category	Shedding

Setup

Remove the jokers. One pack comfortably serves two to four players. At five or more the stock runs dry almost immediately, so shuffle two packs together.

Cards rank in the normal ascending order with the ace at the top: 3, 4, 5, 6, 8, 9, jack, queen, king, ace. The 2, the 7 and the 10 are deliberately missing from that list. They are lifted out of the ranking altogether and given special powers, described under play.

Pick a dealer any way you like for the first hand; after that the loser of the previous hand deals. The dealer gives each player three cards face down in a row, and nobody may look at these. On top of those three, deal each player three more cards face up, so every player has three face-down cards with a face-up card covering each one. Then deal three cards to each player as a hand. That is nine cards per player. The rest goes face down in the middle as the stock.

A quicker way to reach the same layout, and the one most groups use: deal the three face-down cards, then deal six more cards to each player's hand. Look at your six, pick any three of them, and lay those three face up on your face-down cards. The other three stay in your hand. This lets you choose what sits on your table rather than taking whatever the deal gave you, and it is worth thinking about, since your face-up cards are what you will be stuck with in the endgame. Once the first card has been played, your face-up cards are locked and cannot be rearranged.

The player holding the lowest card in hand starts, ignoring the special ranks; in practice that means whoever has the lowest 3, 4 or 5. If nobody wants to check, the player to the dealer's left simply goes first. Play runs clockwise.

Play

On your turn you play one card, or several cards of the same rank at once, from your hand onto the discard pile in the middle. Your card must be equal to or higher than the card showing on top of the pile. Equal is enough, so a nine covers a nine. If you play more than one card, they must all be the same rank as each other. After you play, and only while the stock still has cards in it, draw back up to three cards in hand. If you played three at once, draw three.

If you cannot play, or simply do not want to, you pick up the entire discard pile into your hand and your turn ends. You draw nothing that turn. This is the whole engine of the game: the pile grows, someone eventually gets stuck with it, and they are suddenly holding fifteen cards while everyone else holds three.

Three ranks break the equal-or-higher rule.

The 2 resets. You may play a 2 on absolutely any card, and once it is down the pile counts as clear: the next player may play anything they like on top of it.

The 7 reverses direction of the requirement. You may play a 7 on any card of 7 or lower, and the player after you must then play a 7 or lower, not higher. A 2 or a 10 still gets you out of it, because those two can be played on anything.

The 10 burns. You may play a 10 on any card at all. The whole discard pile, the 10 included, is swept off the table and set aside out of the game permanently, not shuffled back. The player who burned the pile then draws back up to three and plays again, starting a brand-new pile with any card they choose.

Four of a kind burns the pile in exactly the same way as a 10. It does not matter whether one player laid all four at once or whether the fourth was added on top of three that were already there by earlier players. As soon as four cards of the same rank are showing on top of the pile, it is set aside out of the game and whoever completed it draws up and plays again.

The hand runs through three stages. While the stock lasts you always refill to three cards, so you play out of your hand and the layout in front of you is untouched. Once the stock is empty you stop drawing and simply play your hand down. When your hand is empty, you start playing your three face-up cards, and you may play any of them, or two or three of the same rank together. Only when the face-up cards are also gone do you touch the face-down ones.

Face-down cards are played blind, one per turn. Pick one without looking, turn it straight onto the pile, and see what happens. If it legally covers the top card, it stays and play carries on. If it does not, you take it back along with the whole pile into your hand, and you are back to playing out of a hand until you empty it again. You may not look at a face-down card before committing to it, and you may not play two on the same turn.

If you pick up the pile at any stage you must clear your hand out again before returning to your table cards. The order is always hand, then face-up, then face-down.

Goal & scoring

You are trying not to be last. A player is finished the moment their hand, their three face-up cards and their three face-down cards are all gone. The first player out is the winner, but the result everyone actually cares about is at the other end: play continues after the winner leaves until only one player still holds cards, and that player is the loser. The loser deals the next hand, and in most groups is on the receiving end of whatever name the group uses for the game.

There is no point scoring. Each hand stands on its own and you simply play as many as you feel like, though some groups keep a tally of how many times each person has finished last across an evening.

One finishing detail is worth agreeing in advance. If your last card is a 10, or completes four of a kind, you burn the pile and go out, but there is now nothing on the table for the next player to beat. Most groups treat you as out and let the next player lead anything. Others rule that you cannot go out on a burner and must pick the card back up, which makes the endgame considerably meaner.

Variants

Simple Palace (no sevens) — The pared-down version published under the Palace name and the easiest one to teach. Only two ranks are special: the 2 resets the pile so the next player may play anything, and the 10 burns it out of the game. Sevens are ordinary cards with no power at all. Four of a kind still burns. Removing the seven takes out the one rule newcomers reliably forget, at the cost of the pressure that a forced low play creates.

Extra special cards — Groups pile more powers onto more ranks, and almost nobody plays exactly the same set. Common additions: the 3 is transparent or glass, meaning it sits on the pile but the next player must beat whatever card is underneath it; the 8 is invisible in the same way, or else skips the next player entirely; the 9 forces the next play to be equal or lower, doing the job the 7 does elsewhere; and jokers, when left in the pack, either burn the pile or force the next player to pick it up. Decide the full list before dealing, because arguments about a single rank are how this game gets its rude names.

Big-table version — For five to eight players, shuffle two packs together and deal four face-down cards, four face-up cards and a hand of four, refilling to four rather than three. The pile grows much faster with more players feeding it, so burns matter more and picking up is far more punishing. Duplicate cards make four of a kind noticeably easier to complete, which keeps hands from stalling.

Open swapping — Instead of locking your three face-up cards once play begins, you may swap a card between your hand and your face-up row at the start of any of your turns while the stock still holds cards. It softens the game considerably, because a bad opening layout can be repaired rather than suffered, and it gives you somewhere to park a 2 or a 10 for the endgame. Groups that use it usually limit you to one swap per turn.

Rules verified against: Pagat, Bicycle Cards, Wikipedia, Official Game Rules, Game Rules, Cats at Cards, Gambiter, Bar Games 101. Original text; not reproduced from those sources.

President

Also known as	Scum, Asshole, Presidents and Assholes, Bum, Rich Man, Poor Man, Capitalism, Landlord, Warlords and Scumbags, Daifugō
Players	3-8 players (best with 5)
Deck	1 standard deck (52 cards), jokers usually removed; add a second deck above about seven players
Time	20-45 minutes
Difficulty	Easy
Category	Shedding

Setup

Use a full 52-card pack with the jokers taken out. Suits do nothing at all in this game; only rank matters. The order runs, from strongest down, 2, ace, king, queen, jack, 10, 9, 8, 7, 6, 5, 4, 3. The two is the top card and the three is the bottom one, which catches out anyone expecting the usual ace-high order.

For the opening deal of a session, pick a dealer by drawing cards. Deal the entire pack out one card at a time, clockwise. Unless the player count divides into 52 evenly, some players end up with one card more than others, and that is simply accepted rather than corrected. Nobody has a stock or a discard pile of their own; everything is in hand.

The first hand of a session starts with the player to the dealer's left, since no social ranks exist yet. A common alternative is that whoever holds the three of clubs must lead it as the first play.

Every hand after the first begins with an exchange and, usually, a reshuffle of the seating. Once the ranks exist, players sit in order around the table: the President takes the best chair, the Vice-President sits to their left, then the Citizens, with the Vice-Scum and finally the Scum on the President's right. The Scum collects, shuffles and deals the cards for the next hand, which is part of the point of being the Scum.

Add a second pack once you get past about seven players so hands do not shrink to nothing.

Play

The player who leads may put down any single card, or any set of cards of the same rank from their hand: two fives, three jacks, four sevens. Suits are ignored, so a pair is just two cards of matching rank. Whatever the leader plays sets the size of that round.

Going clockwise, each player in turn must either pass or beat the play on the table. To beat it you must put down the same number of cards as the lead, all of the same rank as each other, and of a higher rank than the cards currently on top. A single nine is beaten by a single ten or higher. A pair of nines can only be beaten by a higher pair, never by a single card and never by three of a kind. The size of the play cannot be changed part way through a round.

In the standard game passing is always allowed even when you could legally play, and passing does not shut you out. If the round comes back to you, you may play again. A great many groups play the stricter version in which a pass takes you out of the round for good, so agree on this before you deal; it makes a real difference to how you hold your twos.

A round ends when a play goes all the way around with everyone else passing. Sweep the played cards face down to one side, out of the game, and the player who made that last, highest play leads the next round with anything they like. If that player has just gone out, the

lead moves to the next player still holding cards, going clockwise.

You are out as soon as you play your final card or cards, and you take the highest social rank still unclaimed. The first player out is the President, the second is the Vice-President, everybody in between is a Citizen or Neutral, the second-to-last is the Vice-Scum, and the very last player, left sitting with cards nobody wanted, is the Scum. Some groups stop the hand the moment the Scum is the only player left; others make them play their remaining cards out for the entertainment value. It makes no difference to the result.

Before the next hand is played, the ranks pay out. The Scum hands the President their two highest cards, and they must genuinely be the two highest, no hiding a pair of twos. The President then gives back any two cards they choose, which will normally be their two worst. The Vice-Scum and Vice-President do the same thing with one card each. Citizens exchange nothing. With only three players there is no Vice tier, so just the President and Scum trade two cards apiece. The exchange happens after the deal and before any card is led.

Once the exchange is settled, the President leads to the first round of the hand. Some groups instead give the opening lead to the Scum as a small consolation. Either convention works as long as everyone uses the same one.

Goal & scoring

The immediate goal in each hand is to shed your cards before everyone else and come out as President. The longer-term goal is to stay at the top, because the card exchange means the President starts each new hand with better cards than they were dealt and the Scum starts with worse. Most groups play with no written score at all: the game is about holding the President's chair, and it ends when people have had enough.

If you want a score, the usual method is to award 2 points for President, 1 for Vice-President, 0 for each Citizen, and nothing to the Vice-Scum, with the Scum sometimes charged -1. Play a fixed number of hands, or to a target such as 11 points, and the highest total wins. Playing an agreed number of hands rather than to a target is fairer, since the last few hands otherwise favour whoever is already President.

Two details worth settling early. A player who goes out on their last play still ranks ahead of anyone still holding cards regardless of how the rest of the round finishes. And if two hands in a row leave the same person as Scum, some groups apply an extra penalty such as a three-card exchange, while others leave it alone.

Variants

Passing locks you out — Once you pass, you are finished for that round and cannot play again until the pile is cleared and a fresh lead is made. This is probably the more widely played version, particularly in North America, and it is closer to how the Chinese and Vietnamese climbing games in the same family work. It rewards patience: holding a two back becomes far more valuable when a single pass cannot be taken back, and a player who is running low on cards can be frozen out of a round with a well-timed high play.

Bombs and revolution — Four of a kind, played all at once, is a bomb. Depending on the group it either clears the pile immediately, letting the bomber lead again, or it turns the entire rank order upside down for the rest of the hand so that threes become the strongest card and twos the weakest. A second four of a kind restores the normal order. Some tables run a lighter version in which any single two, or a set of twos, clears the pile on its own without having to beat what is on the table.

Completing the set clears the pile — If your play makes four cards of the same rank sit on top of the pile, counting what previous players contributed rather than just your own cards, the pile is swept away at once and you lead the next round. Playing a pair of kings onto a pair of kings does it. This adds a lot of tactical bite, because it gives a low-ranked player a way to seize the lead without owning the highest cards, and it makes people think twice about splitting a set.

Daifugō (Dai Hinmin) — The Japanese game that President descends from, still widely played and considerably more developed. Jokers are included as wild cards. Playing an eight clears the pile immediately, the rule known as eight-cut, and the player who did it leads again. Four of a kind triggers a revolution that reverses the rank order, and a second one reverses it back. Sequence runs of three or more cards in the same suit can be played as a unit in some versions. Several rules ban going out on a two, a joker or an eight, so a hand that ends on one of those forces the player to take the bottom rank instead of the top.

Table rules and the party version — The reason the game is more often called Asshole than President. The Scum shuffles, deals, clears the pile between rounds, and fetches drinks. The President may invent a rule that holds until they are dethroned, commonly something like a ban on using players' real names or on speaking out of turn. Breaking a rule costs a drink, and so does being caught with a card you should have played. None of this touches the underlying card game, but it is how most people actually encounter it.

Rules verified against: Pagat, Wikipedia, Bicycle Cards, Britannica, Game Rules, Official Game Rules, Cats at Cards, Gambiter, Denexa Games. Original text; not reproduced from those sources.

Slapjack

Also known as	Slap Jack, Slap-Jack
Players	2-8 players (best with 4)
Deck	1 standard deck (52 cards), jokers removed; 2 decks shuffled together for six or more players
Time	10-30 minutes
Difficulty	Simple
Category	Shedding

Setup

Take the jokers out and clear a hard, flat surface everyone can reach. Two to eight can play. Three or more is better than two, because with two players the pile bounces back and forth and a game can run a long time.

Choose a dealer however you like; it matters very little, since nothing about the deal is an advantage. Deal the entire pack out one card at a time, face down, clockwise, until every card is gone. Hands do not need to come out even. With five players two people simply start with an extra card.

Nobody looks at any card, including their own. Square your cards into a tidy face-down stack in front of you. Keep it squared throughout: you play off the top and put winnings on the bottom, and a spilled stack costs you slaps.

Leave the centre of the table clear. That is where the pile builds, and it needs to be within slapping distance of every player, so push chairs in and get elbows off the table before you start.

The player to the dealer's left turns the first card, and play runs clockwise from there.

Play

On your turn, lift the top card off your own stack and drop it face up in the middle of the table, on top of whatever is already there. Turn it away from you, holding the far edge, so that everybody sees the face at the same instant. Peeking at your own card before you play it, or turning it toward yourself, is the standard way to cheat at this game and is treated accordingly.

Almost every card does nothing. You turn it, and the turn passes to the player on your left. The pile just grows.

When a jack appears, everyone races to slap the pile. The first hand flat on the pile takes the whole thing: gather it up, square it, add it face down to the bottom of your stack, and shuffle your stack if you like. That player then turns the first card of a new pile, and play continues clockwise from them. There are only four jacks in the pack, so piles can get big before one shows up.

If two or more hands land at what looks like the same moment, the bottom hand wins, meaning the one actually touching the cards rather than the back of somebody else's hand. If it is genuinely too close to call, the simplest fix is to leave the pile where it is and carry on turning cards.

Slap a card that is not a jack and you pay for it. Take the top card off your own stack, without looking at it, and pass it face down to the player who turned the card you slapped, who puts it on the bottom of their stack. On a table with an aggressive slapper this is where whole games are decided. Note that the penalty card goes to one specific player, not to the middle, so a bad

slap directly rewards the person you slapped over.

When you turn your last card you are not out yet. You stay at the table and you may still slap, so the very next jack is your way back: win that slap and the entire pile becomes your new stack. Miss it, meaning the pile is claimed by someone else while you have no cards, and you are out for good. You get exactly one chance, not an open invitation to keep slapping all game.

A player who is out takes no further part. Their cards are already in circulation, so nothing needs to be redistributed and play carries on around the shrinking table.

One detail worth settling before you deal: a player with no cards who slaps a non-jack has nothing to hand over. The usual ruling is that they are simply out on the spot, having spent their one chance on the wrong card.

Play continues, jack by jack, until only one player is left holding cards.

Goal & scoring

The goal is to end up with all 52 cards. There is no scoring, no rounds and no partial credit: a player who has been knocked out is out, and the last player holding cards has, by definition, got the whole deck.

A full game to 52 does take a while, especially with two players, because a large stack is not safe. One badly judged slap or one missed jack transfers a big pile and swings the whole game. Expect the lead to change hands several times.

If you want a guaranteed finish time, agree a stopping point before you start. Two common ones: play for a set fifteen or twenty minutes and give the win to whoever has the tallest stack, or play until the table is down to two and declare the larger stack the winner.

Speed matters less than people assume. What actually wins is watching the pile rather than your own hand, keeping your slapping hand hovering rather than resting, and not slapping at kings and queens, which at a glance look like jacks and account for most wasted cards.

Variants

More slappable cards — Add extra triggers to the jack: a double, meaning the top two cards match in rank, and a sandwich, meaning two matching cards with exactly one card between them. Piles change hands far more often and the game finishes sooner. Keep piling on triggers and you arrive at Egyptian Ratscrew, which is the same idea with a longer pattern list and face-card challenges bolted on.

Harsher false-slap penalty — Instead of one card to the player who turned the card, a false slapper gives one card face down to every other player. On a full table that is a serious hit and it cures compulsive slapping in about two rounds. A gentler version used with young children replaces the card penalty with a warning and only starts taking cards on the second offence.

Slap and call — You must shout "jack" as you slap. Hitting the pile silently does not count, and calling "jack" when the top card is not one costs a card whether or not your hand landed. It slows the reflex race down slightly and gives a clear tiebreaker when two hands arrive together, since the caller is easier to judge than the hand.

Two packs for a big table — For six or more players, shuffle two 52-card packs together and deal them all out. Eight jacks in the pack instead of four means piles turn over about twice as often, which keeps a large table from sitting through long stretches of nothing. Every other rule stays the same, and the winner still needs every card in play.

Rules verified against: Bicycle Cards, Pagat, Wikipedia, Game Rules, Official Game Rules, PlayingCardDecks, Learning Board Games. Original text; not reproduced from those sources.

Speed

Also known as	Spit, Slam
Players	2-4 players (best with 2)
Deck	1 standard deck (52 cards), jokers removed
Time	5-15 minutes
Difficulty	Easy
Category	Shedding

Setup

Two players, 52 cards, jokers out. Shuffle and deal 20 cards to each player: 15 face down as a personal draw pile, and 5 more as a hand you may look at. That accounts for 40 cards; the remaining 12 build the middle.

Lay the middle out as a single row between you, running left to right: a face-down stack of 5, a single face-down card, a second single face-down card, then another face-down stack of 5. The two single cards in the centre will become the build piles that everyone plays onto. The stacks of five on either end are the side stacks, held in reserve for when play jams.

Put your draw pile face down at your right hand, where you can reach it without looking, and pick up your five-card hand. Each player is responsible for one side stack, the one nearest them on their own side of the row.

When both players say they are ready, each of you puts a hand on one of the two centre cards and you flip them face up together. The game starts the instant they land, so agree on a count first if you want it fair.

Play

There are no turns. Both players play at the same time, as fast as they can manage, and the game runs continuously until someone goes out.

A card is legal on a centre pile if its rank is exactly one higher or one lower than the pile's current top card. Suits are ignored completely. Ranks wrap around at the ace: an ace plays on a king or on a 2, and a king or a 2 plays on an ace. The wrap does not let you skip, so a king can never go straight onto a 2. If the two centre piles show a 9 and a queen, the only cards you can put down are an 8 or a 10 on the first and a jack or a king on the second.

You play from your hand only, one card at a time, and your hand holds a maximum of five cards. Whenever you have fewer than five you may draw from your own 15-card draw pile to top back up. You can do this at any moment and as often as you like, so most players fall into a rhythm of play a card, draw a card. There is no obligation to draw immediately, but hoarding an empty slot only starves you of options. Once your draw pile is exhausted you simply play out whatever is left in your hand.

Because both players are reaching for the same two piles, collisions happen constantly. The standard convention is that the card underneath wins: whichever card physically landed first counts, and the other player picks their card back up and returns it to hand. Play one card at a time with one hand and do not stack several cards down at once.

When neither player can play anything, the game is stuck. Both players then take the top card of their own side stack and flip it face up onto the centre pile next to it, doing so at the same time. That gives two fresh top cards and play resumes instantly. Note that being stuck means

neither player has a legal card in hand, not that either of you has run out of cards.

Work through the side stacks a card at a time as further jams occur. When both side stacks are empty and play jams again, gather the two centre piles, shuffle each one, set them face down as new side stacks, and turn one card from each into the middle to start two fresh build piles. Play then continues exactly as before.

A round ends the moment a player puts down the last card they have, meaning both hand and draw pile are empty. That player calls out Speed, or in some circles slams a hand down on a centre pile, and the round is over immediately. Anything still in the other player's hand is irrelevant; there is no consolation for being close.

Goal & scoring

Be the first to get rid of all twenty of your cards. That is the whole win condition, and there is no point scoring in the basic game.

A single round takes one to two minutes, so Speed is nearly always played as a match: best of three or best of five is the usual arrangement, and some players simply keep going until someone wants to stop and count round wins.

If you want a running score, the two simple methods are one point per round won, or a margin score where the winner of the round scores the number of cards the loser still had in hand and draw pile combined. The margin version rewards a decisive win over a photo finish and makes a comeback across several rounds possible, but it also means the deal has to be counted out carefully every time.

Variants

Jokers wild — Leave both jokers in, giving 54 cards, and deal the extra pair into the draw piles. A joker can be played onto either centre pile at any time regardless of what is showing. The player who plays it announces the rank it stands for, and building continues up or down from that rank. Jokers are the standard escape hatch for a hand that has gone dead, and they cut down on how often play jams.

Three or four players — For three players, give each person their own side stack of five and put three single cards in the middle as build piles, then split the rest evenly as draw piles; adding the two jokers makes the count divide cleanly. For four, shuffle two decks together, deal each player a hand of five plus a draw pile, and use four centre piles with a side stack per player. More build piles keep the game from locking up, but they also make it very hard to watch every pile at once.

Refill only when empty — You may not top your hand up card by card. Instead you play until your hand is completely empty and only then draw five fresh cards. This slows the game down and puts a real cost on dumping playable cards carelessly, since you can strand yourself with one useless card and no way to replace it. It is a common way to level the field between a fast player and a slower one.

No ace wrap — Some households rank the cards strictly from 2 up to ace with no wrap-around, so an ace can only be played on a king and nothing can be played on an ace except a king. This makes aces near-dead cards and lengthens rounds considerably. Agree on it before dealing, because it is the single most common source of mid-game arguments in Speed.

California Speed — A different game that shares the name and the frantic pace. Split the deck evenly between two players. Each player lays four cards face up in a row, forming a shared grid

of eight. Whenever any two of the eight cards match in rank, both players race to slap a card from their own stack on top of one of them; being second means taking your card back. The aim is still to be the first out of cards, but the skill is pattern spotting rather than sequence building.

Rules verified against: Wikipedia, Official Game Rules, Gambiter, Group Games 101, Learning Board Games, Gather Together Games, PlayingCardDecks. Original text; not reproduced from those sources.

Spit

Also known as	Slam, Speed
Players	2 players
Deck	1 standard deck (52 cards), jokers removed
Time	10-25 minutes
Difficulty	Easy
Category	Shedding

Setup

Spit is for exactly two players and uses a full 52-card deck with the jokers taken out. Shuffle and deal 26 cards to each player. From here you each build your own side of the table independently, and it is worth doing this at the same time so neither player gets a head start.

Out of your 26 cards, lay a row of five stock piles in front of you, face down, containing 1, 2, 3, 4 and 5 cards from left to right. That is 15 cards. Turn the top card of each of the five piles face up, so you have five face-up cards showing in a row.

The 11 cards you have not used stay squared up face down beside your row. These are your spit cards, your reserve. You are not allowed to look at them.

Leave a gap between the two rows, in the middle of the table, with room for two piles. Nothing goes there yet; the two centre piles are created by the first spit rather than dealt.

The layout mirrors on both sides of the table, so each player can see the other's five face-up cards throughout. That visibility is the point: you can watch what your opponent is about to need and take it first.

Play

When both players say they are ready, you both call spit together and each of you turns the top card of your reserve face up into the middle, side by side. Those two cards start the two centre piles, and play begins the moment they land.

There are no turns and no waiting. Both players play simultaneously and as fast as they can. A card is legal on a centre pile if its rank is exactly one above or one below the card currently on top of that pile. Suits do not matter at all. Aces wrap: an ace goes on a king or a 2, and a king or a 2 goes on an ace. You cannot skip across the wrap, so a king never lands directly on a 2.

You may only play the face-up card on top of one of your five stock piles, never anything buried. As soon as you move a face-up card, turn up the card that was underneath it so that pile is live again. Play one card at a time with one hand. When both players go for the same centre pile at the same instant, the card that landed first stands and the other player takes theirs back.

When one of your stock piles is emptied, you may move a single face-up card from any of your other piles into the empty space, turning up whatever was beneath it. Only one card moves, not the pile it was sitting on. This is the main way to unblock yourself, and it is worth doing even when you are not stuck, because a spread across five live cards gives you more to play than four.

If the moment comes when neither player can play, you spit again. Both players simultaneously turn the top card of their reserve onto the centre pile on their own side, giving two fresh top cards, and play resumes at once. Repeat that whenever play jams.

If your reserve is empty but your opponent still has spit cards, only they spit, so only one of the two centre piles gets a new top card each time. A player who has fewer than 15 cards at the start of a round deals their stock piles out as far as the cards go, has no reserve at all, and therefore cannot spit; in that case only one centre pile exists for the whole round, started by the other player.

The round ends the instant one player plays the last card out of their stock row. Play stops immediately, and that player has first choice of the two centre piles. They slap the pile they want, which is almost always the one that looks smaller, and their opponent takes the other. If instead the round locks up because neither player can play and neither has a spit card left, the round is over as a standstill, and the player with fewer cards remaining in their stock row gets first choice.

Each player then gathers everything they own: the centre pile they claimed, whatever is left in their stock piles, and any unused spit cards. Shuffle it all together and lay out a new row for the next round, and go again.

Spit is often confused with Speed, and they are close cousins, but the layouts are different. In Spit each player has a row of five stock piles with the top card of each face up and no hand at all; in Speed each player holds a hand of five cards drawn from a single face-down draw pile, and the reserve cards sit in the middle as side stacks rather than in front of each player.

Goal & scoring

The aim is to shed all your cards, and there is no point scoring anywhere in the game. Rounds are just a mechanism for moving cards from the player who is losing to the player who is winning.

Winning a round matters because it lets you take the smaller centre pile, so your next layout is smaller than your opponent's. Shrink it far enough and you drop below 15 cards, which means you deal fewer than five stock piles, hold no reserve, and have no spit pile of your own.

That is how the game actually ends. Once you have no reserve, clearing your stock row leaves you with nothing at all in front of you and nothing to pick up, so you have run out of cards and you win outright. Your opponent, meanwhile, is stuck with a full spread and rounds that get harder every time.

If you would rather not play to a finish, agree on a fixed number of rounds and give the game to whoever holds fewer cards at the end, or simply count round wins.

Variants

Free-for-all slap — Instead of giving the player who went out first choice of centre pile, both players race for them the moment the round ends. Whoever gets a hand on a pile first takes it, so a player who lost the round can still grab the smaller pile with a fast reaction. This adds a second reflex contest to every round and rewards keeping half an eye on how tall each centre pile is getting while you play.

Speed — The closest relative, sometimes sold under the same name. Each player gets a hand of five cards and a face-down draw pile of 15, the two build piles sit in the middle with a five-card side stack beyond each of them, and you refill your hand from your draw pile as you play. There is no stock row and no slapping for piles: the first player to empty hand and draw pile simply wins the round.

Nertz — The multiplayer descendant, also called Pounce or Racing Demon. Each player uses their own full deck with a distinguishable back, lays out a solitaire-style tableau plus a 13-card Nertz pile, and everyone races to build shared foundation piles in the centre starting with aces. The real-time free-for-all feel is the same, but it supports four to eight players and adds a genuine scoring system based on cards played and cards left in your Nertz pile.

No moving into empty spaces — Once a stock pile is cleared, the space stays empty for the rest of the round rather than being refilled from your other piles. This makes rounds shorter and considerably more prone to deadlock, so it works best combined with a generous house rule on spitting. Many people learn Spit this way and are surprised to find that shifting a card into a gap is standard.

Three or more players — Shuffle two decks together and give each player a stock row and a reserve, with one centre pile per player created by a simultaneous spit. Everyone can play onto every centre pile. It is chaotic and the tables get crowded, so many groups shorten the stock rows to four piles per player to keep the layout reachable.

Rules verified against: Pagat, Wikipedia, Official Game Rules, Gamerules.com, Card Game Wiki, Game On Family. Original text; not reproduced from those sources.

MATCHING & COLLECTING

Casino

Also known as	Cassino
Players	2-4 players (best with 2)
Deck	1 standard deck (52 cards)
Time	20-40 minutes
Difficulty	Medium
Category	Matching & collecting

Setup

Two to four players and one standard 52-card deck. Despite the name, nothing is bet and nobody banks: this is a fishing game, where you catch cards off the table with cards from your hand. It plays best head to head. With four, partners sit opposite each other and pool their captures; with three, everyone plays alone.

Pick a first dealer however you like — low card on a cut is the usual method — and pass the deal to the left after each round.

Deal in twos. Two cards to each player, then two face up to the middle, then two more to each player and two more face up. Everyone ends up holding four cards, with four lying face up in the centre. Put the rest of the deck face down beside the dealer. It is used to top hands up later; no further cards are ever added to the table.

Card values in play: an ace is 1 and numeral cards are worth their pips, which includes the two of spades counting 2 and the ten of diamonds counting 10, regardless of what they are worth at scoring time. Jacks, queens and kings have no numeric value and never take part in any addition.

Each player (or partnership) keeps captured cards in a face-down pile, out of play until the round is scored. The player to the dealer's left starts.

Play

On your turn you play exactly one card from your hand, face up, and it must do one of three things: capture, build, or trail. Then play passes to the left. Never more than one card, never fewer.

Capturing. Put your card down and take the table cards it wins, adding them and it to your capture pile.

- By rank: any table card of the same rank as the card you played. A numeral card takes every match at once, so a 7 collects both 7s if two are showing. A face card takes only one matching face card per turn, even when two or three of its rank are sitting there.
- By sum: any group of numeral table cards whose values add up to your card. A 9 can lift a 4 and a 5, or an ace, a 3 and a 5. Face cards can never be part of a sum.
- Several at once: a single card may take a matching rank, one or more separate summing groups, and any build worth that number, all in the same turn. A 9 could take a loose 9, a 6 with a 3, and a build of nine together.

You are never obliged to take everything on offer. Take whichever legal captures you want.

Building. Add a card from your hand to one or more table cards, push them into a pile, and announce what the pile is now worth: "building eight." You must keep a card in hand capable of

capturing that number, and you may not build using only cards already on the table.

A single build is one combination adding to the announced number, such as a 3 and a 5 built to eight. Any player holding the right card may capture it, and any player may raise it by adding a card from hand — laying an ace on a build of eight and announcing nine takes it over, so long as they hold a nine.

A multiple build is two or more separate groups worth the same number stacked together, for example an 8 from hand laid on a 5-and-3 build, still worth eight. Once a build is multiple its value is fixed; nobody may raise it, and only a card of that number takes it. Court cards can never go into a build.

While you own a build on the table you may not trail. On each of your turns you must capture, add to a build, or start another build, and if you can do none of those, you must capture your own build.

Trailing. When you cannot capture or build, or simply prefer not to, lay a card face up on the table by itself. It becomes a loose card that anyone may take.

Sweeps. A capture that clears the table completely is a sweep. Turn one card in your capture pile face up to record it. The player after a sweep faces an empty table and can only trail.

Refilling and the last trick. When every hand is empty, the dealer gives four more cards to each player from the stock, two at a time, and adds nothing to the table. Play carries on the same way. The dealer should announce "last" when dealing the final round so nobody is surprised. After the very last card is played, whoever made the most recent capture sweeps up whatever is still lying on the table — but that is not counted as a sweep. A real sweep made with the final card of the deal does count.

Goal & scoring

Casino is usually played to 21 points across several rounds. Eleven is the common short target, and some groups simply play one round for the points on offer and call it a game.

At the end of each round, sort your captured cards and score:

- 3 points for taking the most cards. If the split is exactly 26 apiece, nobody scores it.
- 1 point for taking the most spades. There are thirteen, so this cannot be tied.
- 2 points for big casino, the ten of diamonds.
- 1 point for little casino, the two of spades.
- 1 point for each ace, four in total.
- 1 point for each sweep.

That is 11 fixed points a round, plus however many sweeps were made.

If two players pass the target in the same round, settle it by counting in the traditional fixed order — most cards, most spades, big casino, little casino, then the aces of spades, clubs, hearts and diamonds — and the first to reach the target wins. Sweeps are earned during play rather than at the count, so they sit on the score before that sequence begins.

Variants

Royal Casino — Court cards get numeric values and join the arithmetic: jack 11, queen 12, king 13. They can be built, captured by sums, and used to capture combinations, which makes builds far more flexible. The ace is usually worth 1 or 14 at the discretion of whoever plays it.

Everything else follows the standard game.

Spade Casino — The spade suit carries the scoring instead of a single point for holding most of it. Each spade you capture is worth a point on its own, the jack of spades scores an extra one, and the rest of the values are unchanged. Game is 61 and is normally pegged on a cribbage board as the points come in, since the totals move so much faster.

Draw Casino — The undealt cards stay as a face-down stock and you draw one after every play to keep your hand at four, so there are no separate deals and no announced last round. Cards simply run out when the stock does. It removes most of the counting advantage of the standard game, since you cannot track how many rounds remain.

Partnership Casino — The standard four-handed form: two teams of two, partners facing each other across the table, captures thrown into one shared pile and scored as a unit. A build made by one partner may be captured by the other, so builds become a way of passing information and setting your partner up rather than a private plan.

Rules verified against: Pagat, Wikipedia, Britannica, Hoyle's Rules of Games, Denexa Games, GameRules.com.
Original text; not reproduced from those sources.

Cribbage

Also known as	Crib, Six-card Cribbage, Noddy
Players	2-4 players (best with 2)
Deck	1 standard deck (52 cards), plus a cribbage board or pencil and paper
Time	20-45 minutes
Difficulty	Medium
Category	Matching & collecting

Setup

Two players, one standard 52-card deck, and a cribbage board with two pegs each. Cards rank king high down to ace low, and for counting purposes an ace is 1, a face card is 10, and everything else is worth its index.

Cut for the deal: low card deals first, and the deal alternates every hand afterwards. Cutting for the first deal matters, because the dealer's edge is real and it swaps every deal.

Deal six cards to each player, one at a time, and put the rest of the deck face down to one side. Look at your six and lay two of them face down in a pile off to the dealer's side of the board. Those four cards are the crib, an extra hand that the dealer alone will score at the end of the deal, so the non-dealer throws to it defensively and the dealer throws to it generously. Neither player looks at the crib until the hands have been played out.

With both hands down to four cards and the crib set aside, the non-dealer cuts the deck and the dealer turns up the top card of the bottom portion, laying it face up on the deck. This is the starter, and it is shared: both hands and the crib count it as a fifth card at the end of the deal, though it is not used during the play. If the starter is a jack, the dealer immediately pegs 2 for his heels.

Both pegs start off the board. Score by leapfrogging the back peg ahead of the front one, so the gap always shows what you just scored.

Play

A deal has two phases: the play, usually called pegging, and then the show.

The play. The non-dealer leads a card face up in front of them and announces its value. The dealer plays a card and announces the new running total, and so on alternately, each of you keeping your own played cards in a personal row rather than a shared pile so the hands can be picked up again afterwards. The running total may never exceed 31.

You peg immediately as you lay a card down: 2 for taking the total to exactly 15; 2 for taking it to exactly 31; 2 for playing a card of the same rank as the one just played; 6 for a third card of that rank; 12 for a fourth. A run of three or more scores a point per card, counting backwards through the cards played since the last reset, in any order, as long as no unrelated card sits among them. Runs can be lengthened by either player: after 6, 4, 5 has scored three, a 3 or a 7 scores four. Suits are irrelevant during the play, and a pair is only a pair if the card just before it matched, not merely if the rank appeared earlier.

Go. If you cannot play a card without pushing the total past 31, say "go". Your opponent then keeps playing on their own for as long as they legally can. When nobody can play, whoever laid the last card pegs 1 for the go, or 2 instead if the total landed exactly on 31. The count then resets to zero and the player who did not lay that last card leads to the new count, with

whatever cards remain. This is the same point people call "last card": when both hands run dry, the player who laid the final card of the deal takes that single point, or 2 if it happened to make 31. It is one point, not a go point plus a last-card point.

The show. When both hands are empty, everyone picks their four cards back up and scores them together with the starter, treating it as a fifth card. Counting happens in a fixed order and must be done aloud: the non-dealer's hand first, then the dealer's hand, then the dealer's crib. That order decides close games, because play stops the moment a peg reaches the game hole. A non-dealer sitting on 118 counts first and can win before the dealer's hand and crib are ever counted.

The deal then passes and the next hand begins. Points are pegged as they are earned, never totalled at the end, and a peg once advanced cannot be moved back; if you overlook points and start the next stage, they are lost, unless you are playing muggins, in which case your opponent takes them.

Goal & scoring

First to 121 points wins, which is twice around a standard board plus the game hole. Points are pegged continuously, and the game ends instantly when a peg reaches 121, mid-count if necessary.

A hand or crib is scored as those four cards plus the starter, and every scoring combination that can be made from those five counts, including the same card used again and again in different combinations:

- Fifteen: any group of cards adding to exactly 15 scores 2, and you count every distinct group.
- Pair: 2 per pair. Three of a kind is three separate pairs and so scores 6; four of a kind scores 12.
- Run: 3 or more in consecutive rank scores 1 per card, and each distinct run counts. A double run of three (a run plus a duplicated rank) scores 8 in all, since it is two runs of three plus a pair.
- Flush: 4 if all four cards in hand share a suit, 5 if the starter matches too. In the crib only the full five-card flush scores; four matching crib cards on their own are worth nothing.
- His nobs: 1 for holding the jack of the starter's suit, in hand or in the crib.
- His heels: 2 to the dealer, pegged at once, when the starter turned is a jack.

The highest possible hand is 29: three fives and the jack matching a starter five. Zero-point hands are common enough to have their own name, a nineteen.

In match play, a loser still short of 91 is skunked and the win is usually worth double; short of 61 is a double skunk.

Variants

Five-card cribbage — The original English form. Five cards are dealt to each player, both discard two, and hands of only three are played, so pegging is short and the crib carries a lot of the scoring. Game is 61, once around the board, and the non-dealer pegs 3 straight away at the start of the game as compensation for not having the first crib.

Three-handed cribbage — Each player is dealt five cards and discards one to the crib. Because that leaves the crib a card short, the dealer also deals one card face down to it straight off the deck. Everyone plays alone on a triangular board, the deal rotates left, and the player to

the dealer's left leads the first card and counts first at the show.

Partnership cribbage — The standard four-player game: two teams of two, partners facing each other, one peg line per team. Deal five cards each and everyone discards one to the dealer's crib. Play proceeds clockwise around the table, and either partner's points advance the shared peg. First side to 121 wins.

Muggins — An optional rule that punishes sloppy counting. If you finish counting a hand or crib and have missed points, your opponent may call "muggins" and peg those points instead. It is common in club and tournament play and worth agreeing on before the first deal rather than after somebody undercounts.

Rules verified against: Pagat, Bicycle Cards, Wikipedia, Britannica, American Cribbage Congress, Masters of Games. Original text; not reproduced from those sources.

Go Fish

Also known as	Fish, Authors, Happy Families
Players	2-6 players (best with 4)
Deck	1 standard deck (52 cards), jokers removed
Time	10-20 minutes
Difficulty	Simple
Category	Matching & collecting

Setup

Use a standard 52-card deck with the jokers out. Suits do not matter at any point; only rank does. Two to six can play, and four is a good number.

Choose a dealer however you like. The deal passes to the left between games. Deal one card at a time, clockwise.

How many cards each player gets depends on the size of the table. With two or three players, deal seven each. With four or more, deal five each. The smaller hand keeps enough cards in the middle to fish from once the table gets crowded.

Spread the undealt cards face down in a loose pile in the centre. This is the pool, also called the pond or the ocean. Keep it spread out rather than squared up so everyone can reach it without knocking it over.

Pick your hand up and sort it by rank so you can see what you already hold. Some groups have everyone lay down any complete book of four they were dealt before the first turn; others require you to wait until you have taken a turn. Either is fine, so long as you agree first. Play starts with the player to the dealer's left.

Play

Turns pass clockwise. On your turn you ask one specific opponent, by name, for one specific rank. Say who you are asking and what you want: "Priya, do you have any sevens?"

Two restrictions govern the ask. You must already hold at least one card of the rank you name, so you can only ask for sevens if there is a seven in your hand. And you must direct the question at a single named player, not at the table in general.

If the player you asked holds any cards of that rank, they must hand over every one of them, not just one. You add them to your hand and your turn continues: ask again, of anyone at the table, for any rank you now hold. A good run can strip several opponents in one turn.

If the player you asked has none of that rank, they say "Go fish." You draw the top card of the pool. If it happens to be the very rank you just asked for, show it to the table and take another turn. Otherwise you keep the card quietly and your turn ends, passing to the player on your left.

Whenever you complete a book, meaning all four cards of one rank, lay it face up in front of you straight away. Completing a book does not end your turn and does not earn you an extra one; carry on with whatever you were doing. Cards in a laid-down book are out of play and cannot be asked for.

If your hand runs empty while the pool still has cards, draw a fresh hand at the start of your next turn: five cards, or however many remain if there are fewer than five. Then ask as normal. Some groups have you draw only one card in that situation, which is harsher but keeps the pool alive

longer; settle it before you start. If your hand is empty and the pool is empty as well, you are out and the remaining players carry on without you.

One detail worth agreeing up front: if you ask a question and the pool is already empty, there is nothing to fish for, so a "go fish" answer simply ends your turn.

The game finishes when all thirteen books have been laid down. Since a book is four cards and the deck holds thirteen ranks, that accounts for every card, and there is nothing left to hold or draw.

Goal & scoring

You are collecting books, and a book is four cards of the same rank. Suits are irrelevant. The player with the most books when all thirteen have been made wins.

There is no point scoring beyond counting books. Seven books wins outright, but nobody usually gets that far in a full table. If two or more players tie for the most books, they share the win, or you can play a decider hand.

Emptying your hand first is not a win condition and carries no reward. A player who runs out early has simply stopped being a target, which is often a disadvantage, because holding cards is what lets you keep asking.

The skill in the game is memory. Every question tells the table what you hold and what you were missing, and every handover tells them what you just gained. Track who asked for what, and go after players you know are sitting on a rank you need.

Variants

Ask for the exact card — Instead of naming a rank, you name a single card by rank and suit, such as the nine of clubs. You still have to hold at least one card of that rank to ask. The tighter target means far fewer successful requests, so hands last longer and remembering exactly which cards have surfaced matters much more. This is how the older parlour game Authors is played.

The blocker plays next — When someone tells you to go fish, the turn moves to them rather than to the player on your left. Turn order becomes unpredictable, which stops players from timing their questions around a fixed rotation, and it rewards answering "go fish" honestly and fast. Widely played as a house rule and worth agreeing on before the deal, since it changes the flow completely.

No requirement to hold the rank — Drop the rule that you must already hold a card of the rank you ask for. Young children find the restriction hard to police and hard to remember, and removing it lets them fish for anything they fancy. It weakens the memory element considerably, because a question no longer tells the table anything about your hand.

Pairs instead of books — Collect pairs of matching rank rather than sets of four, laying each pair down as you make it. There are twenty-six pairs in the deck instead of thirteen books, so cards leave hands much faster and a game finishes in a few minutes. This is the usual simplification for players too young to hold a large hand or keep track of four-card sets.

Happy Families and other purpose-made decks — Dedicated illustrated packs replace ranks with themed sets, most famously the Victorian English game Happy Families, whose deck has eleven families of four members each. Play is identical, but matching by picture rather than by rank makes it accessible to children who cannot yet read card ranks. Many modern children's Go Fish decks work the same way.

Rules verified against: Pagat, Bicycle Cards, Wikipedia, Geeky Hobbies, Ducksters, Solitaire Paradise. Original text; not reproduced from those sources.

Old Maid

Also known as	Scabby Queen, Black Peter, Schwarzer Peter, Old Bachelor
Players	2-8 players (best with 4)
Deck	1 standard deck with one queen removed (51 cards)
Time	10-20 minutes
Difficulty	Simple
Category	Matching & collecting

Setup

Take a standard 52-card deck and pull out one queen, setting it aside face down where nobody can see which one it was. That leaves 51 cards: twelve ranks still complete at four cards each, and queens reduced to three. Everything can be matched into 25 pairs except one queen, which has nothing to go with. That leftover queen is the old maid.

Choose a dealer any way you like; cutting for high card works, and the deal passes to the left between games. Shuffle and deal the entire pack out one card at a time, face down, going clockwise, starting with the player on the dealer's left and finishing with the dealer. It will not come out even. Some players end up with one card more than others, and that is fine and does not affect play.

Everyone picks up their hand and looks at it privately. Before the first turn, each player lays down every pair they were dealt, face up in front of them, and takes no further interest in those cards. A pair is two cards of the same rank; suit and colour are irrelevant. If you hold three of a kind, you may only discard two of them and must keep the third. If you hold all four of a rank, put down two pairs. A player whose whole hand pairs off in this opening discard is left with nothing, and is out and safe before the first turn is taken.

Play

Play moves clockwise. The dealer goes first, though many families instead start with the player to the dealer's left; agree before you begin, since it changes nothing but who is exposed first.

On your turn you hold your hand out to the player on your left, spread face down like a fan so the backs are toward them and no faces show. That player takes one card of their choice, blind, and adds it to their hand. If the card they drew makes a pair with something they already hold, they lay that pair down face up at once. If it does not, they simply keep it.

The player who just drew then becomes the one who offers, fanning their own hand face down to the player on their left, and so on around the table. Cards therefore move steadily around the circle, each player always drawing from the neighbour on their right and always offering to the neighbour on their left.

Shuffling your hand before you offer it is the whole skill of the game. Keeping the old maid in one spot, glancing at it, or holding it slightly proud will get it read instantly, especially by children, who are usually better at spotting a tell than adults expect.

When a player's hand becomes empty, whether by laying down a pair or by having their last card drawn away, that player is out and safe. Skip them from then on. Offering and drawing simply pass to the next player who still holds cards, closing the circle up as it shrinks.

The hand ends when every card that can be paired has been paired. At that point exactly one card is left in the game, held by exactly one player: the odd queen. There is no scoring round

and no way to unload it once you are the last player holding cards, so the ending is always the same shape.

Goal & scoring

Your aim is to get rid of every card in your hand and, above all, not to be the one holding the unmatched queen at the end.

There is no point scoring. Everyone who empties their hand wins equally, and the single player left with the old maid loses that hand. Position or order of going out does not matter; being out first carries no extra credit.

Because the loser is decided entirely by blind draws and by how well people disguise their hands, results swing wildly from deal to deal. Groups that want a longer session usually play a fixed number of hands and count how many times each person was stuck as the old maid, with the lowest count winning overall. Some play instead until one player has been the old maid three times and is out.

Variants

Dedicated Old Maid deck — Purpose-made children's decks replace the standard pack with illustrated character pairs plus one unpaired Old Maid card. Play is identical, but the matching is by picture rather than rank, which makes it far easier for very young players who cannot yet read card ranks reliably.

Joker as the odd card — Instead of removing a queen, leave the deck complete at 52 and add a single joker, giving 53 cards. All four queens stay in and can be paired; the joker is the card nobody wants. This is how the game is usually played in Japan, where it is known as babanuki, and it saves you from fishing a card out of the pack.

Scabby Queen — A British version in which three queens are removed so that the queen of spades is the doomed card, and the loser takes a forfeit. Traditionally the loser cuts cards from the pack and is rapped across the knuckles with the deck a number of times set by the card drawn. Most groups now drop the physical penalty and keep only the named target card.

Black Peter — The continental European form, called Schwarzer Peter in Germany and Svarte Petter or Svarteper in Scandinavia. A jack, usually the jack of spades, is the unpairable card rather than a queen, and the loser is often marked with a smudge of soot or a drawn-on moustache. Many countries sell dedicated Black Peter decks in the same spirit as illustrated Old Maid packs.

Any odd card — Remove a card at random, face down, without anyone seeing which one it was, so nobody knows what the unpairable card is until the hand is nearly over. This kills the strategy of tracking one known queen and stops experienced players from reading the table so easily. A Philippine version, ungguy-ungguyan, is played this way.

Rules verified against: Pagat, Wikipedia, Bicycle Cards, Gambiter, Card Game Wiki, Ducksters. Original text; not reproduced from those sources.

War

Also known as	I Declare War, Battle, Bataille
Players	2-4 players (best with 2)
Deck	1 standard deck (52 cards), jokers removed
Time	15-45 minutes
Difficulty	Simple
Category	Matching & collecting

Setup

Take a 52-card deck and remove the jokers. Shuffle well and deal the whole pack out face down, one card at a time, so that each player has an equal stack. With two players that is 26 cards each; with three, deal 17 each and set the odd card aside; with four, 13 each.

Nobody looks at their cards at any point. Keep your stack squared up face down in front of you, and leave a clear space in the middle of the table where cards will be turned up. Some players like to keep a second face-down pile beside the first for cards they win, so the two never get mixed; either way, cards you win go under the cards you have not played yet.

Ranking is the usual one with aces high: A, K, Q, J, 10, 9, 8, 7, 6, 5, 4, 3, 2. Suits are irrelevant from start to finish. There is no dealer advantage and no first player, because everybody acts at the same moment, so choosing who deals is purely a matter of convenience.

Play

Play is a series of battles. On each battle every player takes the top card of their stack and turns it face up in the middle at the same time. Whoever turned up the highest rank wins all the cards on the table and adds them face down to the bottom of their stack. Suits never break a tie and never matter.

When the two highest cards are equal, that is a war. Each tied player puts three cards face down on top of the pile they are contesting, then turns one more card face up. The higher of the new face-up cards takes everything: in a two-player war that is ten cards, the two originals plus eight more.

If the face-up cards of the war are also equal, the war simply repeats. Each player again lays three down and one up, adding another eight cards to the pot, and again the higher card takes the lot. There is no cap on this. A second round is often called a double war and a third a triple war, and while three or four consecutive ties are rare, nothing in the rules stops the sequence from continuing.

Sources differ on how many cards go face down. Three down and one up, often chanted as I-declare-war while dealing them, is the version most people learn. Bicycle and Pagat give a shorter form with a single card face down and a single card face up, which puts six cards at stake instead of ten and is noticeably quicker. Settle which you are using before the first tie, since it changes how fast stacks change hands.

Running short of cards mid-war is the edge case that causes arguments. The usual ruling is that you put down as many face-down cards as you can spare and turn your very last card face up as your fighting card; if you have exactly one card left, that card is your face-up card and there are no face-down cards at all. A player who cannot produce a single card has lost. Some groups play the stricter version where failing to complete a full war loses the game outright.

When your face-down stack runs out, turn over the cards you have won and carry on with them. Shuffle them first. This is not merely tidiness: if won cards are stacked back in a fixed order the game can settle into a loop that never resolves, and a meaningful share of unshuffled games are mathematically endless.

With three or four players everyone flips at once and the highest card takes the whole table. If two or more players tie for highest, only those players go to war; anyone who was beaten leaves their card in the pot and takes no further part in that battle. A player whose cards are gone is out, and the rest continue until one player holds everything.

Goal & scoring

You win by taking every card in the deck. There is no scoring, no tricks to count and nothing to write down, and no decision is ever made by a player: once the cards are dealt the entire result is fixed by the shuffle and by how won cards are returned to each stack.

Because cards keep circulating, a game can run far longer than beginners expect. Fifteen to thirty minutes is typical, but an hour is entirely possible, and a game between two evenly matched stacks can churn without either side making progress.

Most households therefore cap it. Play for a set time, or a set number of battles, and whoever holds the most cards at that moment wins. Counting is quick because the totals always add up to 52. Another common cap is to play three wars and stop, or to declare a win as soon as one player is reduced below some agreed number of cards.

Variants

One card down, one card up — On a tie each player buries only a single card face down before turning up the deciding card, so six cards are at stake in a two-player war rather than ten. This is the form printed by several standard references and it shortens the game noticeably, since fewer cards are locked into each contested pot and players run their stacks down less abruptly. Repeated ties are handled the same way, one down and one up each time.

Casino War — The banked table-game version, played against a dealer. You bet, then you and the dealer each get one card and the higher card wins even money. On a tie you choose: surrender and forfeit half your stake, or go to war by matching your original bet, after which the dealer burns three cards and deals one more to each of you. Beating or tying the dealer on that second card wins even money on the raise while the original bet pushes. Many tables pay a bonus if the second cards tie as well, and most offer a side bet on the first two cards tying, typically at 10 to 1.

Three or more players — Deal the pack out as evenly as possible, setting aside any remainder, and have everyone turn a card at the same time. The highest card sweeps the table. If two or more players tie for the lead, only the tied players fight the war, and cards already beaten stay in the pot as spoils for the eventual winner. Players drop out as their cards run out and the last one standing wins. Four players with two decks shuffled together keeps the same feel with more cards in motion.

Timed War — Set a timer, often ten or fifteen minutes, and play until it goes off. Whoever holds more cards at that point wins. This is the standard fix for the game's biggest flaw with young children, since it guarantees an ending and gives a clear result without anyone having to concede a stalemate that could otherwise go on indefinitely.

Jokers wild — Leave both jokers in the deck as the highest cards, outranking aces and each other only by a tie. With 54 cards the two-player deal is 27 apiece. Jokers make sweeps more dramatic without adding any decisions, and if two jokers meet you resolve it as an ordinary war.

Rules verified against: Pagat, Wikipedia, Bicycle Cards, Dice Game Depot, Geeky Hobbies, Gamerules.com, Wizard of Odds, Card Game Wiki. Original text; not reproduced from those sources.

BLUFFING

BS

Also known as	Cheat, I Doubt It, Bullshit, Bluff, Doubt It
Players	2-10 players (best with 5)
Deck	1 standard deck (52 cards), jokers removed; 2 decks shuffled together for six or more players
Time	15-30 minutes
Difficulty	Simple
Category	Bluffing

Setup

Take the jokers out. One pack handles up to about five players comfortably. From six up, shuffle two packs together, which also raises the number of cards you can claim at once from four to eight.

Two can play, but the game is thin at that size: with only one opponent you know exactly where every card you do not hold must be, and there is almost nothing to hide. Four to six is where it works.

Pick a dealer any way you like; the deal passes to the left afterwards. Deal the entire pack out one card at a time, clockwise, until nothing is left. Hands will not come out even unless the player count divides into 52, and that is fine: a one-card difference has no effect. With four players everyone starts with thirteen.

Pick your cards up and sort them by rank. You want to be able to see at a glance how many of each rank you hold, because the whole game is a running calculation of what you can honestly play and what you will have to fake.

Leave the middle of the table clear for the discard pile. It starts empty and can grow to most of the deck.

The player to the dealer's left goes first and must claim aces. A common alternative is that whoever was dealt the ace of spades leads instead, again claiming aces. Either works; just say which one you are using before the first card goes down. Play runs clockwise.

Play

Ranks are claimed in a fixed ascending cycle: ace, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, jack, queen, king, then back to ace and around again. The cycle belongs to the table, not to any player. Whatever rank the previous player claimed, you claim the next one up.

On your turn, place one to four cards face down on the pile and say out loud how many and of what rank, for example "two nines". The rank is dictated by the sequence. The number is up to you, and so is whether the cards are actually what you said. You may play any cards you like under any claim.

You must play at least one card. You cannot pass and you cannot play zero. This is the engine of the game: sooner or later the sequence reaches a rank you hold none of, and you have to lie.

With a single pack the ceiling is four cards, since there are only four of each rank. With two packs it is eight. Claiming more than the pack allows is itself a giveaway.

Once your cards are down, any other player may challenge by calling "BS!" (or "Cheat!" or "I doubt it!"). The window stays open until the next player's cards hit the table, at which point the claim stands for good. If two people call at once, the first one heard takes it; agree in advance that ties go to whoever sits nearer the challenged player's left, so you are not arguing about it mid-game.

A challenge is resolved by turning over only the cards that were just played, not the whole pile:

- If every one of them matches the claimed rank, the claim was honest and the challenger was wrong. The challenger takes the entire discard pile into their hand.
- If even one card is not the claimed rank, the player who played them takes the entire discard pile into their hand.

Either way the pile is now gone from the table and the next player starts a fresh pile. Picking up does not cost you anything else, and it does not skip anyone.

A challenge does not reset the rank cycle and does not change whose turn is next. Play carries on with the player to the left of whoever just played, claiming the next rank up, no matter who ended up with the pile. If the last claim was eights, the next claim is nines even if the eights turned out to be garbage and their owner is now holding twenty cards.

If nobody challenges, nothing is revealed. The cards stay face down on the pile and their true identity is never learned, which is exactly what makes the game work: a successful lie is invisible.

Going out has one wrinkle. Playing your last cards does not finish you immediately; you are only out once the challenge window has closed. If someone calls BS on your final play and you were lying, you take the pile and you are back in the game with a fistful of cards. If you were telling the truth, the challenger takes the pile and you have won. If nobody calls, you are out and the game ends there.

Goal & scoring

You are trying to empty your hand. The first player to get rid of every card, and survive any challenge to that last play, wins.

There is no point scoring at all. A game is a single deal and takes as long as it takes.

Many groups do not stop at the winner. Play carries on with the remaining players, finishing positions are recorded as each one goes out, and the last player still holding cards is the loser. That version gives everyone something to play for after the first person leaves, and it means being second-to-last is a real result rather than nothing.

A few practical points that decide games. Lie small: claiming one card is far less suspicious than claiming four, and it also costs you less to be caught early when the pile is short. Watch the pile size, because a challenge is only worth making when the pile is small or when you are certain. And count: if you hold three queens yourself, anyone claiming three queens is caught before they finish the sentence.

Variants

Free choice of rank (Bluff) — Instead of a fixed ascending cycle, the player who starts a pile names any rank they like, and every player after them must claim that same rank until a challenge happens. Whoever ends up taking the pile starts the next one with a rank of their own choosing. This removes the forced-lie pressure of the ascending version, since you can open on

a rank you actually hold, but it makes reading other players harder because nobody is ever obliged to lie. This is the version usually meant by the names Bluff and I Doubt It in older books.

Up or down — You may claim either the next rank above or the next rank below the previous claim. After "two tens" the next player may claim nines or jacks. Some groups also allow repeating the same rank, which gives you three choices every turn. It makes honest play much easier, so lies become rarer and correspondingly more valuable, and it kills the standard tactic of counting ahead to work out which rank will land on you.

Restricted challenge window — Rules differ on who may call and for how long. The most common version lets any player call until the next player's cards touch the pile. A tighter house rule allows only the player to the immediate left of the one who played, which keeps the game fast and stops the whole table ganging up. A looser one lets anyone call at any point before the pile is next collected, so a claim can be caught several turns later. Settle this before dealing; it is the single most argued-about rule in the game.

Extra penalty for a bad call — A wrong challenger takes the pile and additionally draws a card from the hand of the player they falsely accused, or from every player at the table. This clamps down on speculative calls made purely to keep the pile small, and it makes challenging a real decision rather than a free option. Groups that find their games stalling because everyone calls constantly usually add some version of this.

Two-pack table — For six or more players, shuffle two 52-card packs together. Everyone still gets roughly the same hand size, but each rank now has eight copies, so claims of five, six or more are legal and the arithmetic of catching a liar changes completely. Holding three of a rank no longer proves much. Piles grow much larger, which makes getting caught genuinely punishing.

Rules verified against: Pagat, Bicycle Cards, Wikipedia, Official Game Rules, Game Rules, Denexa Games, PlayingCardDecks, Gambiter. Original text; not reproduced from those sources.

CASINO

Blackjack

Also known as	Twenty-One, 21, Vingt-et-Un
Players	2-8 players (best with 5)
Deck	1 to 8 standard decks shuffled together; six is the casino norm, one or two is fine at home
Time	30-60 minutes
Difficulty	Easy
Category	Casino

Setup

One person is the dealer and everyone else bets against them. A casino table seats up to seven players, so with a dealer you want between two and eight people. At home, either appoint a permanent dealer or rotate the role, since the dealer holds a small built-in advantage and rotating shares it around.

Shuffle the decks together. Casinos deal six decks from a shoe; one or two decks shuffled by hand is perfectly good for a kitchen table. Agree a minimum and maximum stake before you start, and give everyone chips or counters.

Card values: 2 through 10 count face value, jacks, queens and kings count 10, and an ace counts 1 or 11, whichever suits your hand better at the moment. A hand holding an ace that can still count 11 without busting is called soft, so ace-6 is a soft 17 and can be hit without risk. Once counting the ace as 11 would put you over 21 it reverts to 1 and the hand is hard. Suits are irrelevant throughout.

Every round starts with each player placing a bet in their betting spot. Once all bets are down, the dealer deals clockwise: one card to each player, one to themselves face up, then a second card to each player and a second to themselves face down. That face-down card is the hole card, and it is what the whole game turns on. In shoe games the players' cards are dealt face up and are not touched; in hand-dealt single-deck games they come face down and players pick them up. Neither changes the odds.

An ace plus any ten-value card in your first two cards is a blackjack, also called a natural. It is the best hand in the game and is settled at a better rate than an ordinary win.

Play

Before anyone acts, the dealer checks for a natural. If the upcard is an ace, the dealer first offers insurance: any player may put up a side bet of up to half their original stake, and that bet pays 2 to 1 if the dealer's hole card turns out to be a ten-value card. A player holding a blackjack against a dealer ace may instead take even money, which is the same wager in disguise and pays their hand 1 to 1 immediately. When the upcard is an ace or a ten-value card, the dealer then peeks at the hole card. If it is a natural, the round is over at once: insurance is paid, every ordinary hand loses, and any player who also holds a blackjack pushes.

Otherwise play begins with the player on the dealer's left and moves clockwise. Each player finishes their hand completely before the next one starts. Your options on your first two cards are:

Hit. Take another card. You may keep hitting as long as you are under 21.

Stand. Take nothing more and let the hand ride.

Double down. Double your original bet and take exactly one more card, then you are done whatever the total. Most tables allow this on any two cards; some restrict it to hard totals of 9, 10 or 11.

Split. If your two cards are the same rank, put out a second bet equal to the first and separate them into two hands. Each gets a second card and is then played out in turn. If a split hand pairs again you can usually split once more, up to a limit of three or four hands in total. Splitting is subject to two firm exceptions: split aces receive exactly one card each and cannot be hit again or resplit, and an ace paired with a ten after a split counts as an ordinary 21, not a blackjack. Whether you may double after splitting varies by house.

Surrender. Where offered, you may abandon the hand before drawing any card and forfeit half your bet. This is late surrender, meaning it is only available after the dealer has confirmed no natural. Plenty of tables do not offer it at all.

Going over 21 is a bust. Your cards are taken and your bet is collected immediately, before the dealer plays. That is the whole basis of the house edge: you lose a bust hand even if the dealer goes on to bust as well.

When every player has finished, the dealer turns the hole card up and plays by fixed rule, with no choices at all. The dealer draws to any total of 16 or less and stands on any total of 17 or more, counting a soft 17 such as ace-6 as a 17 and standing on it. The dealer never doubles, never splits, and never surrenders. If the dealer busts, every player still standing wins.

Goal & scoring

The aim is to finish with a hand closer to 21 than the dealer's without going over. You are not racing the other players; every hand is settled independently against the dealer alone.

Settlement once the dealer's hand is complete:

A winning hand pays 1 to 1, so a 10-chip bet returns your 10 plus 10 more. A blackjack pays 3 to 2, so a 10-chip bet returns your 10 plus 15. A tie is a push and your stake comes back untouched. A losing hand or a bust loses the stake. Insurance is settled separately from the hand it was placed alongside, so you can lose the hand and still collect on insurance, or the other way round.

A blackjack beats any 21 built from three or more cards, and it is paid at the better rate; a three-card 21 against a dealer blackjack simply loses. Two blackjacks push.

There is no running score. You play as many rounds as you like and count your chips at the end. Sensible play matters: with correct basic strategy the house edge on a standard six-deck game with these rules sits well under one percent, but insurance is a losing bet at almost any count, and a table paying 6 to 5 on blackjacks instead of 3 to 2 costs you roughly an extra 1.4 percent.

Variants

Dealer hits soft 17 — The dealer must draw on a soft 17 such as ace-6 rather than standing on it, and stands only on hard 17 or any 18 and up. This is now the more common rule on casino floors and it costs the player about a fifth of a percent, because it lets the dealer improve a weak 17 into a winner. Tables normally state which rule applies in print on the felt: "dealer must stand on all 17s" or "dealer hits soft 17".

6 to 5 blackjack — The natural pays 6 to 5 instead of the traditional 3 to 2, so a 10-chip bet wins 12 rather than 15. It looks like a small change and is not: it adds roughly 1.4 percent to the house edge, which is more than every other rule on the table combined. Often paired with a single deck to make the game look generous. Check the payout before you sit down.

Late surrender — You may fold a bad hand before drawing to it and lose only half your bet, once the dealer has confirmed they do not have a natural. It is mainly used on hard 16 against a dealer 9, 10 or ace, and on hard 15 against a 10. Offered on many six and eight-deck games, rarely on single or double deck, and often not signposted, so ask the dealer.

Rotating banker at home — Rather than appointing one permanent dealer, pass the deal around the table so everyone takes the house side in turn, either after each hand or after each shuffle. Whoever holds the deal is the banker and covers all bets from their own stack, so agree a table maximum they can actually pay. Rotating matters because the dealer side carries a real edge over a session; leaving it with one person all night is not a fair game.

Pontoon — The British relative of the game, and a genuinely different animal. Both dealer cards go face down, hitting is called twisting, standing is sticking, and you may instead buy a card by increasing your stake. You cannot stick below 15. Five cards totalling 21 or less is a five-card trick and beats everything except a pontoon, the ace plus ten-value hand; both pay 2 to 1. The dealer wins all ties, so there is no push.

Rules verified against: Wizard of Odds, Vegas Aces, Casino.org, PokerNews, BetMGM Casino Blog, Denexa Games, Wikipedia. Original text; not reproduced from those sources.